

Chapter 1

A PREAMBLE TO THE GRAND ITIHĀSA

Is it possible at all to measure knowledge? Interestingly, Mahābhārata narrates an account of such a measurement¹. It is said that once the Devās came together and quantified knowledge. The four Vedas, Rig, Yajur, Sāma, and Atharva, were placed on one side of a weighing scale, and Mahābhārata was placed on the other. Vedas, devoid of a beginning or end, are considered an infinite source of wisdom. Both Itihāsas, including Mahābhārata, acknowledge the wisdom of Vedas as supreme². In fact, Mahābhārata reveals that all Itihāsas and purānās are intended to convey the supreme ideas of Vedas to untrained people³. However, as the Devās put them to test, the scales tipped toward Mahābhārata.

Mahābhārata is described as the pañcamaveda or the fifth Veda. In fact, the Chāndogya Upaniṣad describes all purānās and Itihāsas as pañcamaveda⁴. Sometimes Nāṭyaśāstra⁵ and Āyurveda⁶ are also categorized similarly. Then again, for

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all its vastness and completeness that is comparable to the Vedas, the title best suits Mahābhārata.

The name Mahābhārata itself underlines the story of weighing knowledge, 'Mahatvāt bhāravatvāt cha mahābhāratam uchyate'. Because of the huge size and weight of this Itihāsa, it was named Mahābhārata⁷. Even if taken literally, Mahābhārata is great in size and weight, with eighteen lakh words or one lakh ślokas. That means it is four times bigger than the first Itihāsa, Rāmāyana, one of the foremost works of poetry⁸. Even the Greek epics 'Iliad' and 'Odyssey' combined level to only one-tenth of Mahābhārata. Briefly put, Mahābhārata is the biggest literary work in the history of mankind⁹. In addition to its size and weight, the magnificence and greatness of Mahābhārata lies in its philosophical, spiritual, and devotional treatises, complex discussions on Dharma - Adharma, political strategies, warfare, history, geography, aesthetics, and a lot more.

Alongside the ten Upaniṣads and Brahmasūtra, Śrī Ādi Śaṅkarācārya considered Śrīmad Bhagavadgītā of Mahābhārata, for laying the foundations of his darśana. He described Bhagavadgītā as the quintessence of all the Vedas¹⁰,

गीता-शस्त्रम् समस्त-वेदार्थ-सार-संग्रह-भूतम्।

*gītā-śāstram samasta-vedārtha-sāra-saṅgraha-bhūtam*¹¹.

Just like Śrī Ādi Śaṅkarācārya, Ācāryas like Śrī Abhinavagupta¹² (Proponent of Kāśmīraśaiva philosophy), Śrī Mādhvācārya¹³ (Dvaita philosophy), Śrī Rāmānujācārya (Viśiṣṭādvaita philosophy) among several others, have

discussed Bhagavadgītā through their Bhāṣhyās. Today, there are around 227 discourses on Bhagavadgītā in samskr̥tam alone¹⁴. During our struggle for freedom from British colonisation, Lokmānya Tilak wrote his commentary on Bhagavadgītā, 'Gītārahasyam', with a focus on Karmayoga, to inspire freedom movement¹⁵. Many warriors who stood at the forefront like M K Gandhi and Araviṇḍa Maharṣi were inspired by the Bhagavadgītā¹⁶. Bhagavadgītā continues to illuminate the world from within Mahābhārata, offering infinite possibilities for philosophical and spiritual thinking.

Mahābhārata gives us lessons in statecraft, alongside lessons in forging alliances within personal, social, and national spheres. Celebrated stutis like Viṣṇu Sahasranāma and Śiva Sahasranāma and that of Devatās including Bhagavān Śiva, Bhagavān Viṣṇu, Durga Devī, Agni Devā, etc. are also seen in Mahābhārata. Even today, there are countless television series, movies, animated films, theses, discourses, and novels that tap into Mahābhārata. This means that the impact of this Itihāsa has not been confined to literary and cultural realms alone. Mahābhārata has influenced the lives of Indians in a number of ways, be it in the nomenclature of places and people, traditions, temples, and so on. Earlier its influence was restricted to the Indian subcontinent and countries like Indonesia and Cambodia. However, today it is well-known all over the world.

What is an Itihāsa?

Mahābhārata is one of the two great Itihāsas born in India. 'Iti iha āsa', literally means 'so indeed it was'¹⁷. However,

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Itihāsa is not merely history or a description of history. It is **not a myth or an epic**.

History is the analysis and interpretation of the past¹⁸. History becomes historical fiction when imagination and literary tools are added to it. Myths are stories that revolve around the divine or people with divine powers, even though it discusses ideologies, morality, and righteousness¹⁹.

Aristotle observed that an **epic** is a **narrative** that revolves around a particular incident discussing its origin, progress, and consequences²⁰. However, **Itihāsas do not** have any of these characteristics.



धर्मार्थकाममोक्षानाम् पूर्ववृत्तं कथायुक्तं इतिहास प्रचक्ष्यते

dharmārtha kāmamokṣānām pūrvavṛitham

kadhayuktham itihāsa prachakshyathe

Itihāsas explain the four **puruṣārthas**, dharma, artha, kāma, and mokṣa by narrating historic events in the form of stories²¹. This purpose and nature of Itihāsas are clearly visible in Mahābhārata, from head to toe.

It would be a grievous error to consider the literary genre of a particular language as universal and equate unique literary genres of other languages to it. This would make for a huge categorical blunder. And such is the case if we classify an Itihāsa as an Epic. **Swāmi Vivekānanda** describes **Itihāsas** as the **encyclopedia of knowledge and Aryasamskṛti**. He further added that Itihāsas envisage an **ideal culture** that our civilisation is yet to achieve²².

Borrowing Maharṣi Veda Vyāsā's own verses on Mahābhārata²³,

धर्मे चार्थे च कामे च मोक्षे च भरतर्षभ
यदिहास्ति तदन्यत्र यत्रेहास्ति न तत्कचित्

dharme cārthe ca kāme ca mokṣe ca bharatarṣabha
yadihāsti tadanyatra yannehāsti na tatkvacit

Mahābhārata 1.56.33

O Bharatarṣabha! (the best among the Bharatas), whatever is found in Mahābhārata about dharma, artha, kāma, and mokṣa, may be found elsewhere. But, what is not in this Itihāsa, cannot be found anywhere else?

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Anyone who has even the slightest idea about Mahābhārata will testify that there is no exaggeration in these words. This śloka proudly proclaims the timeless relevance and importance of Mahābhārata. The puruṣārthā, **Kāma**, means **desire**. In worldly life, an individual desires a number of things. All of those can be called kāma. To fulfil any desire, one has to put in the right kind of effort, working hard enough to match the value of what is desired. The puruṣārthā, **Artha**, represents this **effort** (effort translates to wealth). In the quest to acquire artha and fulfil kāma, care must be taken to not disrupt the existing balance towards nature and fellow beings. This care may be considered as the Dharma. Mokṣa is the ultimate freedom from our confinement to this bondage of Artha and Kāma. The culture of Bharat celebrates the idea that one must acquire **Artha in accordance with Dharma and experience Kāma also in accordance with Dharma**. Living this way, all beings walk toward their final goal, which is Mokṣa. Itihāsas sketch this ultimate vedic truth.

इतिहास पुराणाभ्यां वेदं समुपबृंहयेत् ।
बिभेत्यल्पाश्रुताद् वेदो मामयं प्रहरिष्यतीति ॥

*itihāsa purāṇābhyāṃ vedam samupabṛṃhayeta.
bibhetyalpaśrutād vedo māmayaṃ prahariṣyatīti.*

Mahābhārata **1.1.205**

Mahābhārata proclaims that, since Vedas themselves are afraid of people with **half knowledge (alpaśruta)**, because they may interpret Vedas wrongly, the essence of Vedas have to be explained with the help of Itihāsas and purāṇās²⁴.

Hence, the subjects of discussion in Mahābhārata are the puruṣārthās, the very fabric of life, and some heroes who lived in the past. Moreover, the characters of Mahābhārata, along with being historic personalities also reflect the subtle internal conflicts in our minds. That is why Mahātmās like Sat-guru Śrī Mātā Amritānandamayī Devī tell us that the Mahābhārata war is also a representation of our internal struggles.

The Author

Maharṣi Veda Vyāsa is the author of Mahābhārata. He was born as Kṛṣṇadwaipāyana to Satyavati and Parāśara Muni. He divided the Vedas into four and composed the fifth Veda, Mahābhārata. He is known by the name Dwaipāyana as he was born on an island. Traditionally Maharṣi Veda Vyāsa is considered as the author of the eighteen purāṇas²⁵, the commentary on Patañjali Yoga Sūtras and one of the fundamental texts of Vedānta philosophy - Brahmasūtra.

Śrīmad Bhāgavata Purāṇa depicts Maharṣi Veda Vyāsa as one of the twenty-two main avatārs of Bhagavān Viṣṇu²⁶. In Śrīmad Bhagavadgītā, Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa reveals that “Among Maharṣis, I am Vyāsa.”²⁷.

In addition to being the composer of Mahābhārata, Maharṣi Vyāsa is also a powerful character within, appearing at the beginning and the end of the Itihāsa and capable of controlling the flow and direction of the story. Some of the regional versions say that Maharṣi Vyāsa was unable to find a suitable person to write Mahābhārata, which was overflowing

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within him. He wanted to write it for the prosperity of the world. He then approached **Brahma** for a solution. As per His advice, **Bhagavān Mahāgaṇapati** was given the task of writing Mahābhārata from Maharṣi Vyāsa²⁸. According to the story, Veda Vyāsa and Gaṇapati formed a pact before beginning the Itihāsa. In the pact, Bhagavān Gaṇeśa said that Maharṣi Vyāsa should dictate the entire Itihāsa without any pause or interruption while Veda Vyāsa in return asked that he write only after fully understanding the meaning of the narrated verses. Thus Mahābhārata was composed by Maharṣi Vyāsa of the incarnation of Bhagavān Viṣṇu and was written by the omniscient son of Bhagavān Śiva, Gaṇeśa on Brahma's advice.

Birth of the Itihāsa

Mahābhārata records that it was **Lomahaṛṣaṇa's son, Ugrasravas**, who narrated Mahābhārata to the **Rṣi** in **Śaunaka's satrā at Naimiṣāranyaṃ**. Here the Rṣis speak thus to **Ugrasravas**, "Please narrate to us this great Itihāsa magnificently strung together by Parvās, the essence of the four Vedas, praised by the Devās and the Brahmarṣis and is inclusive of all śāstras and the meaning of the Vedas." Mahābhārata was composed by **Satyavati's son, Maharṣi Veda Vyāsa** and later he narrated it to his **son Śuka** and His other **śiṣyas**.

In Ādi Parva of Mahābhārata, it is said that the great Maharṣi Veda Vyāsa authored a great book with **sixty lakh ślokas**. Out of this, **thirty lakh ślokas** are meant for the devās, fifteen

lakhs for the pitrs, fourteen lakhs for the gāndharvas, and the remaining one lakh for mankind. Mahābhārata presents itself as a narration by Vaiśampāyana, as commanded by Maharṣi Vyāsa, in the sarpa-satra yajña of King Janamejaya. And also later, as a narration by Lomaharṣana's son, Ugrasravas, at Naimiṣāranyaṁ in Śaunaka's satra, to the Ṛṣis.

Inside Mahābhārata

In Ādi Parva, Maharṣi Vyāsa uses a beautiful metaphor to sketch and compare the characters Yudhiṣṭhira and Duryodhana. Duryodhana is a huge tree, angry by nature. Karṇā is its trunk, and Śakuni is the branch. Its flowers and fruits represent Duṣṣāsana. And the naive Dhṛtarāṣṭra forms the roots of that tree of anger. On the other hand, Yudhiṣṭhira is a great tree of Dharma. Arjuna is the trunk, and Bhīma is the branch. The flowers and fruits are Nakula-Sahadeva. And its roots, Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa Himself, the Brahmajñas, and the Vedas²⁹.

Apart from the main characters, we find unearthly characters like Devas, Asuras, Rākṣasas, Yakṣas, Gandharvas, Apsaras, Nāgas etc. Then we have different kinds of people like Kings, Purohitas, Traders, Sūtas, Ṛṣis, Queens, Dāsas, Niṣādas, Mlecchas, Yavanas etc. Birds, animals and reptiles among other living beings are also there alongside mountains and rivers.

Forests, groves, palaces, puṇyatīrthās, grounds, and river banks alongside Indraloka, Nāgaloka, etc. are the backdrops of this grand Itihāsa. While the important parts of the story

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are set with Hastināpura and Indraprastha as the centre, this position is often taken by places like Dwāraka, the Ganges, Magadha, the Kingdom of Pāñcāla, and the Kingdom of Matsya. Although the Itihāsa primarily narrates the account of Bharatavamśa, it also portrays Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa's Vṛṣṇivamśa, Pauravavamśa, etc. alongside many others.

Though the Itihāsa's primary subjects are the life and times of the Kauravās and the Paṇḍavās, Mahābhārata begins with Janamejaya, the grandson of Arjuna's son Abhimanyu. And when the past is narrated in the Itihāsa from this point, we are taken back to the time of Bhīṣma and beyond, to Kuru and Bharata, and further even to the origin of the world. Even though the heart of the story lies with the five sons of Pāṇḍu, the interventions of Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa, Kṛṣṇa-Draupadī and Maharṣi Kṛṣṇa Dwaipayana Vyāsa alter the course of the story considerably. Alongside this main story, Mahābhārata also narrates the accounts of Garuḍa, Nala, Duṣyanta, Bhagavān Śrī Rāmacandra, Maharṣi Viśvāmitra, Emperor Śibi, Rāntideva, Bhagavān Paraśurāma, and King Hariścandra among others as antecedents or subplots.

Conclusion

Mahābhārata teaches us to perceive the actions of others, not just based on the context of their current life but also on their previous lives, and on the complicated trail of Karma and Karmaphala. The Itihāsa touches on the hard and deep realities of life that lie beyond the saṅkalpa of the twin notions of Truth – False or Good – Evil. It does not

hold back from discussing the Adharma of the Dharmic side and the Dharma of the Adharmic side. The Itihāsa reminds us that Dharma tattva is subtle and difficult to grasp if not impossible³⁰.

Known as *Jaya*, *Bhārata*, *Kṛṣṇaveda*, and *Mahābhārata*, this grand Itihāsa begins with the chanting of the maṅgalācaraṇa śloka. The same śloka is also found in Mahābhāgavatam.

नारायणं नमस्कृत्य नरं चैव नरोत्तमम्।
देवीं सरस्वतीं व्यासं ततो जयमुदीरयेत्॥

*nārāyaṇam namaskṛtya naram caiva narottamam
devīm sarasvatīm (vyāsam) tato jayam udīrayet*

Before starting *Jaya*, one has to offer *namaskāram* and bow down to the supreme *Nara-Nārāyaṇa*, *Sarasvatī Devi* and *Maharṣi Vyāsa*. *Nara-Nārāyaṇas* are *Mahāmunis*, who were once part of *Bhagavān Viṣṇu* Himself. *Mahābhārata* says that, in the *Dwāpara Yuga*, they took birth as *Śrī Kṛṣṇa* and *Arjuna*. Chanting the maṅgalācaraṇa, let us approach *Mahābhārata*, as per the Itihāsa's own instructions, with *Śraddhā* and *Saddharmaniṣṭhā*³¹. Let us discover the mysteries of *puruṣārthās* with the aid of the divine words of wisdom from *Maharṣi Vyāsa*. Let the study of *Mahābhārata* become an initiation, *upanayana*, into the divine wisdom of *Bhāratmāta*.

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Chapter 2

**MAHĀBHĀRATA -
A BRIEF SUMMARY**

The web of a complex plot is aesthetically woven
by the Itihāsa author Maharṣi Vyāsa.

But what is the main thread that ties it all
together? Let's find out.



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Chapter 2

MAHĀBHĀRATA - A BRIEF SUMMARY

It is believed that the great Mahārṣi Veda Vyāsa recited Mahābhārata in the form of one hundred Parvas. Parvas can be considered equivalent to episodes of a grand chronicle. Vaiśampāyana narrates the Mahābhārata to King Janamejaya at the Sarpa Satra conducted by the king. The majority of the text is presented as a conversation between King Janamejaya and Vaiśampāyana. Later, Ugras̥ravas re-narrated the complete story at Naimiṣā forest (Naimiṣāranya) and classified them into main eighteen Parvas, the first being known as Ādiparva. Certain present-day scholars who do extensive research on this work believe that the first few Parvas of the 100 Parva classification serve the purpose of granting an admit card to the reader to enter the itihāsa. It summarizes the whole work, gives subtle hints on the purpose of this itihāsa, employs metaphors and tropes to unveil hidden messages, and so on.

Our humble attempt here will be to take a trail walk through the important incidents of this itihāsa.

In the first Parva, known as Ādiparva, apart from such a summarization, most markedly, the story of Bhārat is narrated. 'Bharatasya deśam Bhāratam'. It is believed that Bhārat (the traditional name of India) derived its name from this valiant King Bharat, who was born in a forest to Śakuntalā and King Duśyanta. Interestingly, the story of the birth of author Kṛṣṇadvaiپāyana Vyāsa is also recounted in Ādiparva.

The main thread starts when the powerful King Śāntanu of Bharata lineage begets a son Devavrata through Gaṅgā Devī. To allow for his father's desire to marry a fisherwoman, Satyawatī, Devavrata took a stern vow that he would never marry and dedicated himself to a life of unbroken chastity. This challenging feat, the 'Bhīṣma Pratiज्ञā', which means 'terrible vow', earned him the name 'Bhīṣma'. This name remained the celebrated epithet henceforth. Later, his father blessed him with a boon that he would die only when he wished to.

King Śāntanu and Satyawatī had two sons, Citrāṅgada and Vicitravīrya. They were very courageous and ruled the kingdom one after the other. Citrāṅgada died at the hands of a Gandharva in a fierce battle. Later, Bhīṣma abducts Ambā, Ambikā and Ambālikā as brides for Vicitravīrya. He abducts these Kāśī princesses, exhibiting his valour and might, at a Svayamvara function in Kāśī King's palace, in accordance

with one of the forms of marriage. Vicitravīrya, too, dies young without leaving a progeny. The itihāsa author, who is also a stepbrother to Bhīṣma, comes as requested by their mother, and through his grace Dhṛtarāṣṭra, Pāṇḍu and Vidura are born. Dhṛtarāṣṭra is born blind, while Pāṇḍu turns out to be pale-complexioned. Pāṇḍu marries Kuntī and Mādrī.

Kuntī, in her childhood days, had obtained a divine mantra from Mahārṣi Duryāsa for her patience and devotion. Using that mantra, she could invoke any Deva and acquire a son from that Deva. Out of her childish curiosity, she tests the efficacy of the mantra by invoking Sūrya Deva and ends up with a child from him. This child who bore divine armour and earrings at the time of birth is Karṇā. But Kuntī placed him inside a box and set him afloat in a river since she was



unwedded, very scared, and didn't really know what else to do. A childless charioteer would find and raise this child who in the future would be the sturdiest opponent to the rest of Kuntī's sons. A despicable design of destiny?

After marriage to Pāṇḍu, Kuntī and Mādrī use this same mantra and thus were born the five Pāṇḍavas, each from a different Deva. Yudhiṣṭhira from Yamadharma Deva, Bhīma from Vāyu Deva, Arjuna from Indra Deva and Nakula - Sahadeva from the two Aśvinī Devās. During this time, the daughter of the Gāndhāra King, Subala, gets married to the blind King Dhṛtarāṣṭra. Denying the vision that her husband lacks, this queen ties a cloth around her eyes and willingly remains blind throughout the itihāsa. This act of hers receives plentiful praise. Queen Gāndhārī's brother Śakunī also shifts himself to Hastināpura. He becomes the mastermind behind most of the evil plots of Duryodhana and Karna.

Turning impatient after knowing that Kuntī gave birth to Yudhiṣṭhira, a pregnant Gāndhārī beats her stomach only to give birth to a lump of flesh. However, the itihāsa author Mahārṣi Vyāsa divides this flesh into one hundred and one equal parts, keeps them inside mud pots, and with his blessings are born the hundred Kaurava brothers and one sister of whom Duryodhana is the eldest.

The five sons of Pāṇḍu were born when they were in the forest, and shortly thereafter, Pāṇḍu departs owing to a curse. Kuntī and the five sons return to the kingdom. These five sons and the hundred sons of Dhṛtarāṣṭra grow

up in mirth and merriment, but the practical jokes of the physically powerful Bhīma nurture deep hatred and jealousy in the mind of Duryodhana who tries through many ways to end the life of Bhīma.

Meanwhile, an important parallel story is narrated. Elsewhere, much before the Pāṇḍavas were born, Droṇa, born of Mahārṣi Bharadvāja, befriends prince Drupada at the Gurukula. Being close friends, the Drupada prince offers Droṇa half the kingdom once after they grow up. Droṇa learns Dhanurveda, the art of archery, from Bhagavān Paraśurāma himself. Struggling through a poverty-stricken phase of life, Droṇa visits his childhood friend Drupada seeking wealth. Drupada insults and sends Droṇa back, stating, "Friendship can only be among equals".

Skilled in dhanurvedyā, Droṇa gets appointed as the chief weaponry tutor of all the princes' of Hastināpura. Burning with the rage of insult, Droṇa seeks vengeance through his pupils. Once the education was over, he demanded his disciples to capture and bring Drupada to him as Gurudakṣiṇā. Kauravas, including Karṇā, suffer a terrible defeat against Drupada's army, while the Pāṇḍavas, who fight next, defeat and bring King Drupada tied as demanded. After seizing his kingdom, Droṇa offers half of it back to Drupada himself and mocks, "As now we are equal, there can be friendship between us", and sends him back to his palace. Humiliated, Drupada undertakes a big sacrifice seeking revenge. And from the sacrificial fire, are born two important

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characters; **Dr̥ṣṭadyumna** who will kill Drona in the future, and the beautiful **Draupadī**.

When the Pāṇḍavas and Kauravas grow in age, scared of losing the **Kingship to Yudhiṣṭhira, Duryodhana, and Karṇa** plot an evil scheme to end all the five brothers by burning them in a **wax palace**. Fortunately, the Pāṇḍavas are timely informed of this, thanks to **Vidura**, and they manage to escape through a hidden tunnel. But their escape remains a secret, and the impression is maintained that they got killed in the wax palace incident.

In the next few years, they roam around in the forest killing Rākṣasas like **Baka and Hidimba**. This adventure trip culminates in a **svayamvara at Pañcāla Deśa**, where Arjuna, disguised as a Brahmin, shoots down a mechanised moving target. As Arjuna wins over Draupadī in the svayamvara, the rest of the kings succumb to jealousy and start fighting the Pāṇḍavas. For the first time in the itihāsa, Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa enters the scene, settling the dispute with his diplomatic skills and charisma. By a stroke of destiny connected to previous birth, Draupadī is married to all five brothers, and shortly all of them return to their paternal kingdom. **Dhṛtarāṣṭra** offers half the kingdom back, as suggested by **Bhīṣma, Drona, and Vidura**, and the Pāṇḍavas move to **Khāṇḍava** where they build a **huge palace**.

The second Parva - **Sabhā Parva** starts with the building of a **huge palatial court / sabhā** by the Pāṇḍavas. After that, they do a **Rājasūya Yajña** and expand their empire. Duryodhana,

bedazzled by the beauty of the new palace of the Pāṇḍavas at Indraprastha and their unprecedented wealth, grows jealous and plots a new plan. They invite the Pāṇḍavas for a game of dice in which Yudhiṣṭhira bets and loses everything, to the deceitful games of Śakunī. He would even go to the extent of betting all his siblings, himself, and their wife Draupadī. Thereafter occurs one of the most heinous and disgraceful incidents, the dishonouring of Draupadī.

Having obtained Draupadī in the bet, provoked by the words of Karṇā, Duḥśāsana, a younger brother of Duryodhana, drags her onto the court as she resists. In front of a court disgraced with the silence of powerful men, Duḥśāsana tries to disrobe Draupadī. She pleads for Dharma and receiving no solid response, prays and surrenders herself to Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa. Divine intervention from Kṛṣṇa enables a continuous flow of the dress thereby saving her honour. Realizing the adharma that happened, the blind king Dhṛtarāṣṭra repents and offers boons to Draupadī, and accordingly, all the Pāṇḍavas were set free of the bet. Bhīma, out of rage, takes an oath to pierce the chest of Duḥśāsana and break the thighs of Duryodhana. Even before the Pāṇḍavas reach back to their kingdom, Duryodhana and his accomplices convince Dhṛtarāṣṭra to call them back for another round of dice game, this time with a new gamble. The losers have to give up their kingdom and stay in the forest for twelve years and one year in disguise afterward. After completing the thirteen years, they can return and obtain their kingdom back. According to Kṣatriya dharma, Yudhiṣṭhira accepts the challenge even

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knowing that Śakunī would resort to deceit. The expected happens and the Pāṇḍavas lose the game. They, along with Draupadī, leave for the forest for twelve years.

There begins the third Parva, Āraṇya Parva, 'Āraṇya' meaning forest. During those years in exile, they would kill many adharmic beings, and earn many divine weapons like Pāśupatāstra. They spend the last year in disguise in the land of King Virāṭa. This is the Virāṭa Parva. The daughter of King Virāṭa gets married to Abhimanyu, the son of Arjuna. They complete their stipulated period and return. But Duryodhana had no intention of giving back the kingdom. War became inevitable.

In the next Parva, Udyōga Parva, Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa takes an extraordinary step to avoid war by going on a peace mission. Duryodhana makes his stance clear that not even a pinch of space will be given to the Pāṇḍavas. However, the peace mission fails desperately when the wicked Duryodhana even tries to capture Śrī Kṛṣṇa. Bhagavān here reveals his Viśvarūpa, the all-encompassing divine form.

The preparations for war begin. The whole of Kṛṣṇa's army (Yādava Sainyā) fights for the Kauravās, while an unarmed Kṛṣṇa serves as the charioteer of Arjuna in the Pāṇḍava side. Bhīṣma leads the Kaurava army while Drṣṭadyumna leads the Pāṇḍava side. The next ten days till the fall of Bhīṣma is the Bhīṣma Parva.

The news of the fall of Bhīṣma renders Dhṛtarāṣṭra curious. Dhṛtarāṣṭra, then asked Sañjaya how Bhīṣma fell. Sañjaya thus narrates the war from day one to Dhṛtarāṣṭra. He says that

when both armies were arrayed against each other, Arjuna fell into a dilemma born out of attachment. There happens one of the most profound conversations in Mahābhārata - The Bhagavadgītā. It contains the quintessence of life, its problems, and solutions. Finally, a motivated Arjuna picks up his Gāndīva and the war begins.

The following Parva is named after Droṇa, appointed as the new major general of Kauravās after Bhīṣma. It is the 11th day of war and Kauravas under the leadership of Droṇa resume the fight against the Pāṇḍavas, whose army is still led by Dr̥ṣṭadyumna. The death of many top commanders from both sides is described in this parva. Abhimanyu, Drupada, Ghaṭotkaca, Droṇa, Jayadratha, etc. are some commanders who get killed in the war.

Karṇā assumes the leadership of the Kaurava army after the death of Droṇa and the war continues. This is Karṇā Parva. Śalya, the King of Mādrī and the charioteer of Karṇā rebuked him for his adamancy and foolishness in thinking of killing Arjuna. Between them, there happens a strong exchange of words. A great warrior himself, Śalya advises Karṇā, and the arrogant Karṇā ignore him. Here Śalya narrates the story of a Crow and Swan to Karṇā, in an attempt to make him understand his limitations. The greatest duel of the Mahābhārata war is fought between Karṇā and Pārtha and finally, Pārtha slays Karṇā with the help of Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa.

The next parva is the Śalya Parva. After the deaths of the chief warriors, the King of Mādrī becomes the General of the

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Kaurava Army. Śalya dies at the hands of Dharmarāja. Bhīma and Duryodhana have a battle of maces. Balarāma, the elder brother of Śrī Kṛṣṇa had taught the art of mace fighting to both Bhīma and Duryodhana. Unable to watch the fight between his own students, Balarāma starts a holy pilgrimage along the Sarasvatī River during this time. At the end of this battle, Duryodhana suffers a major injury and collapses on the field.

Then comes Sauptika Parva. The warriors Kṛtavarmā, Kṛpā, and Aśvatthāmā, the son of Droṇa, went to the field of battle in the evening and saw King Duryodhana lying on the ground, his thighs broken, and his body covered with blood. Firm in his anger, Aśvatthāmā vowed that he would not take off his armour without killing all the Pañcālas led by Drṣṭadyumna, the Pāṇḍavas, and their allies. That night, Aśvatthāmā entered the Pāṇḍava camp to kill them all. He caught Drṣṭadyumna in his sleep and smothered and suffocated him to death. He then battled the rest of the camp single-handedly and murdered everyone, including all the sons of the Pāṇḍavas. Grief-stricken by her son's death and mourning the deaths of her father (Drupada died earlier in the war) and brother, Draupadī resolves to fast unto death. Moved by Draupadī's words, Bhīma runs after the son of his guru (Droṇa), Aśvatthāmā. The rest of the Pāṇḍavas and Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa catch up with Bhīma and they reach Aśvatthāmā. Driven by destiny and out of fear of Bhīma, Aśvatthāmā unleashed the divine astra, Brahmaśira, urging

it to destroy the Pāṇḍavas. Arjuna also had the extremely rare knowledge of the same weapon and he releases that as a countermeasure. There appear two rishis, Vyāsa and Nārada who warn both about the destructive nature of this released weapon. Arjuna retrieved his weapon in respect of their opinion while Aśvatthāmā couldn't. He redirects this weapon to the fetus in the stomach of Abhimanyu's wife Uttharā. The newborn will be dead however Kṛṣṇa gives life to him who continues the Kuru lineage. Śrī Kṛṣṇa and Vyāsa curse Aśvatthāmā for his reckless act. After the funerals of all the kings were performed with offerings of water, Kuntī acknowledges Karṇa as her son. Thus concludes Sauptika Parva.

After that comes the Strī Parva which recounts the pitiful lamentations of the wives of the heroes and Gāndhārī, and Dhṛtarāṣṭra's wrath and fainting. They see the Kṣatriya warriors lying on the field of battle unable to escape destiny - dead sons, brothers, and fathers. There the extremely wise king, Yudhiṣṭhira burned the dead bodies of the kings according to prescribed rites.

After that follows (the twelfth) the Śānti Parva. This Parva narrates Dharmārāja Yudhiṣṭhira's despondency at having killed his fathers, brothers, sons, maternal uncles, and relations by marriage. On the bed of arrows, Bhīṣma narrates the duties and laws of a Dhārmic king. Also recounted are norms during emergencies and rules of time and cause. Finally, the wonderful path to salvation, Mokṣa Dharma, is described in detail.

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Then follows the Anuśāsana Parva. Here, Yudhiṣṭhira, King of the Kurus, was composed after learning about righteous conduct from Bhīṣma. It describes the rules of Dharma and Artha in detail, the different rules of donation and their fruits, the different merits of charity depending on the persons to whom charity is given, the rules of living, the rites of individual conduct, and the unmatched supremacy of truth. As this Parva concludes, the great Bhīṣma ascends to heaven.

The fourteenth, the Aśvamedhika Parva, begins with the excellent story of Saṁvarta and Marutta, the discovery of the golden treasures, then the birth of Parīkṣit who was burnt almost dead by Aśvatthāmā's Brahmāśira and revived by Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa again. Then there is Yudhiṣṭhira's Aśvamedha Yajña and Arjuna's journey with the sacrificial horse, and his battle with many kings.

Then follows the fifteenth Āśramavāsika Parva. Here, giving up the kingdom, King Dhṛtarāṣṭra, accompanied by Gāndhārī and Vidura, retires to the forest. The virtuous Pṛthā, who always served her superiors, left the kingdom and her sons and followed the old couple.

The sixteenth Parva is called Mausala Parva. The word musala means pestle. The Yādavas are cursed by Rishis that the musala will destroy them. Grass turns to clubs and the Yādavas kill each other with these. Balarāma and Kṛṣṇa give up their lives on earth, as they understand that their

'Avatāra lakṣya' is accomplished. Arjuna's powers vanish and he becomes a normal person, unable to rescue even Yādava women from plunders.

'Mahā' means great and 'prasthānika' means journey or departure. Thus, 'Mahāprasthānam' literally means great journey but stands for departure from this world or death. Mahāprasthānika Parva is about the departure of the Pāṇḍavas for the Himālayas and their deaths, one after another. It has the story of Dharmadeva disguised as a dog and Yudhiṣṭhira's ascent to heaven in his physical body.

In the eighteen-Parva classification, Mahāprasthānika Parva is the seventeenth. Svargārohaṇa Parva is the concluding Parva of the itihāsa and here once again the author Kṛṣṇadvaipāyana extols the core message of Mahābhārata.

In the concluding verses, Vyāsa laments thus, "Thousands of mothers and fathers and hundreds of sons and wives arrive in this world and then depart elsewhere. There are thousands of reasons for joy and hundreds of reasons for fear. From one day to another, they afflict those who are stupid, but not those who are learned. I am without pleasure and have raised my arms, but no one is listening to me. If artha and kāma result from Dharma, why should one not pursue Dharma? For the sake of kama, fear or avarice, and even for the sake of preserving one's life, one should not give up Dharma. Dharma is eternal. Happiness and unhappiness are transient. The Ātman is eternal, but other reasons are transient."

Thus concludes Mahābhārata, the largest literary project ever created, for transcending the dualities of life in this and other

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worlds. One who understands this purpose of Mahābhārata will alone benefit from its reading.

There are many important parts that had to be skipped when summarizing, like Jarāsandha Vadha, the curse of Urvaśī, the story of Śikhaṇḍī, Śiśupāla Vadha, Yakṣa Praśna, how Bhīma killed Kīcaka and many many small stories like the story of Sāraṅgaja bird, Vyādha Gītā, etc. We would recommend all to read the entire itihāsa to benefit a holistic understanding.

(This summary is partly extracted from the English Translation of Mahābhārata by Bibek Debroy)



Chapter 3

MAHĀBHĀRATA - WHATS AND WHATNOTS

Now we know the main story line.

Yet, some may ask, what treasures lie within its narration that warrant our devoted attention? What lessons and insights does this venerable epic offer to us, the modern generation? Why, indeed, should we seek to befriend this ancient one who has stood the trials of time?



MAHABHARATA WHAT'S AND WHAT NOTS

From what we have seen
in the previous chapter
that the war was not a
just war. It was a war
between two brothers.
The Pandavas and the
Kauravas. The Pandavas
were the rightful heirs
of the throne. But the
Kauravas, led by Duryodhan,
were the ones who
started the war. They
were the ones who
killed the Pandavas.
They were the ones who
burned the Pandavas.
They were the ones who
killed the Pandavas.

Chapter 3

MAHĀBHĀRATA - WHATS AND WHAT NOTS

An Itihāsa is an effort to convey the universal truth as stories related to humans and non-humans. Mahābhārata, one of the greatest Itihāsa composed by Veda Vyāsa, aims to express and narrate eternal truths on human nature. It touches upon various aspects like how truth can be experienced, communicated, understood, and verified. Such truths are derived from thousands of years of observation, study, and analysis by Ṛṣis and other dedicated scholars. The Ṛṣis are often called 'Mantra dr̥ṣṭākkal'. 'Dr̥ṣṭākkal' means one who has experienced it. They are not the creators of aphorisms. These truths are verbal expressions of what they have experienced and understood in their meditations. All the aphorisms expressed by the great Ṛṣis based on their experiences have been combined, classified, and edited by the great sage named Kṛṣṇa Dvaipāyana. Since he edited it, he came to be known as the editor of the Vedas or Veda

Vyāsa. Each Veda has been classified into four texts - **Samhitā**, **Āraṇyaka**, **Brāhmaṇa**, and **Upaniṣads**. All four categories consist of three types of statements: **Praśasti Vākya**, the **Vidhi Vākya**, and the **Jñāna Vākya**.

The decorative statements that narrate the **fame or infamy** of a deity, an incident, a person, or an experience are called **Praśasti Vākya**. Since it involves the components of fame and infamy, there must be an act of **commission and omission** based on the likes and dislikes of the concerned person. Committing and omitting will take away the veracity of the narrative. So, **all the Samhitā statements are Praśasti Vākyas, not the statements of the** truth. For example, it is natural for human beings to commit to one thing based on their likes and dislikes. If someone praises something, it does not necessarily mean that they have made a statement based on an authentic evaluation of their experience. It would be out of their personal choices, likes, and dislikes.

Another aspect is the **Vidhi Vākyas**. **Vidhi Vākyas** are generally concerned with the **dos and don'ts** in a person's life. People's discretion to do or not do something depends on their individual contexts. Such deciding factors depend on the situation. For instance, a person might be expected to do something in a particular context but not the same in another context. It is a variable entity. These two types of statements have been compiled in **Brāhmaṇās and Āraṇyakās**.

The third aspect is the statement of truth. It is like an equation. The syntactic order of the statements can't

change in the structure or the meaning of the statements. For example, $2+2=4$. The statement is still valid if you put it in the reverse order, $4=2+2$. Similarly 'Ahaṁ Brahma asmi', 'Brahma ahaṁ asmi' or 'tatvaṁ asi', 'Asi tatvaṁ'. No matter how you change the order of the words, the meaning of the statement remains unchanged. The Upaniṣads mainly consist of statements of truth. Brahma Sūtra is a text on the Vedānta system. It is derived from Vedas by taking statements of truth and placing them in a systematic order.

Another important aspect of Mahābhārata is the Gītā. Gītā shows how the lessons from ancient texts can be applied in a practical context. The Vedic aphorisms are actualized in the Gītā in accordance with real-life circumstances. So, the Vedas or the Upaniṣads are the sourcebooks, Brahma Sūtra is the text and Bhagavadgītā is the technology with which the lessons are enacted and undertaken.

Mahābhārata is a text that contains the technology of the Vedānta system. That's why Vyāsa called Mahābhārata the fifth Veda.

Why is it called the Fifth Veda?

If one needs to learn Veda, there are two major aspects related to the person learning. One is eligibility and the other is competence. For instance, those who pass a degree course are eligible to become civil servants. But they are not all competent to become civil servants. Similarly, according to the Indian system of thought mentioned in the Vedas, all human and non-human beings are eligible to attain Mokṣa

– the ultimate purpose of every living being. Unlike other religious notions, heaven is not the final destination in Indian thought. It is not a permanent destination. Once your time is over, you may have to come back to earth.

According to Indian systems of thought, every living being is eligible for the attainment of Mokṣa. In the case of human beings, all of them are not competent in learning the Vedas. They can fulfil the eligibility criterion but may not be competent to learn the Vedas. A set of rules must be observed for learning Vedas. Human beings may fail to practice **rigorous vratas** and training systematically envisaged by the Ṛṣis for this purpose. Here comes the relevance of Vyāsa's fifth Veda- Mahābhārata. It conveys lofty ideas in simple words. Thus, it helps those who are eligible for the attainment of Mokṣa but are incompetent due to their inabilities. And to attain Mokṣa, Mahābhārata offers a distinctive means for them through the multifaceted life experiences illustrated in it. The principal purpose of writing Mahābhārata was to illustrate how Dharma operates and explicates the operation of Dharma in numerous contexts. The brilliant and imaginative narration of the text teaches incalculable lessons eloquently to whoever studies it.

What is the essence of Dharma?

Vyāsa says that the **essence of Dharma is Niṣkāma Karma** which is the **central** topic explained in **every anecdote** of Mahābhārata. Niṣkāma Karma means the performance of Karma without having the touch of the Kārmic elements. A

person's act of serving others by controlling his sense organs and mind is called Nişkāma Karma. Nişkāma Karma is widely misunderstood by the presumed intelligentsia as a confined term, discussed and elaborated only in the Bhagavadgītā. Nişkāma Karma suggests that one has to be selfless while performing Karma. It is found everywhere in the universe.

For instance, the human body is dynamic. Anything dynamic must undertake some action as well as undergo some reactions. So, inaction or inactivity is logically an inconceivable term. The human body must inevitably be engaged in some activities.

While undertaking actions, one must keep in mind that it should be beneficial to everyone. Being a social animal, everything is part of human life - both good and bad. Everyone must commit themselves to Nişkāma Karma at some point in their lives. One must be responsible for their actions / dormancy and cannot blame any external force for its results. One must have control over their actions, think about its pros and cons, and control their sense organs and manas. This is what Mahābhārata teaches you through the life stories of various characters.

Chapter 4

**DHARMIC INSIGHTS
OF A BUTCHER**

Are you ready to unlock the secrets of the ages?

The greatest teachers await us in the most unexpected places. You shouldn't be surprised when a Butcher imparts invaluable insights on Dharma.



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Chapter 4

DHARMIC INSIGHTS OF A BUTCHER

It is fair to say that the Bhagavadgītā is the **crest jewel** of Mahābhārata. Bhagavadgītā is the **pendant of the long string** of pearls, which we call the Mahābhārata. But there are two other Gītās - **Uddhava Gīta** and **Vyādha Gīta**. Bhagavadgītā was delivered by **Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa** to Arjuna, and Uddhava Gīta by **Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa** to Uddhava, his long-standing **friend and disciple**. The **Vyādha Gīta** is a **highly philosophical** account explicating **Advaita philosophy**. Vyādha stands for **'butcher'**, therefore, **Vyādha Gīta** is the Gīta delivered by a butcher. A butcher's job, you may know, is cutting and selling meat. This **Vyādha Gīta** comprises profound philosophical nuances. There exists a story behind it that holds the essence of **karma yoga**, the definition of **work and worship**.

A young Brahmin boy decides to renounce the world, go to a forest, leaving his old parents, and do **tapas (austerities)** to attain Bhagavān (God) and truth. This may resonate with

the story of Gautama Buddhā, but this happens before the time of Buddhā. In fact, this happens at the time when the Pāṇḍavas are in the forest. His parents requested their son to stay back and look after them as they were getting old and had no one else to take care of them.

But the adamant son left them and went to the forest one fine day. He started doing tapas in that forest. For many years he did meditation, tapas, etc. Traditionally, most people think that spirituality is doing things like leaving everything, going to a forest, and doing tapas there and that was exactly what he did. After several years, his concentration improved and he gained unique powers. One day, a crane came and sat on top of the tree under which he was meditating. Crane does not discriminate between who is sitting under the tree. The crane is incapable of distinguishing a yogi from an ordinary person. The bird then happened to evacuate, and it fell on the Yogi's head. He snapped out of his meditation. The man looked up at the crane with his eyes burning with fury. And the bird was burned to ashes. The man was amused at his own power and grew proud of himself.

He usually went to seek bhikṣā from the nearby village. He beseeched for food by chanting 'bhavati bhikṣām dehi'. He went to one house where a lady was preparing food. She was busy taking care of her husband who had just come home from work. So she told the young Brahmācārī to wait. This infuriated him and he yelled at her for making a great man like himself wait till her chores were done.

But the lady replied with a smile, “My Son, Do you think I’m a crane so that you can burn me up? I am not a Crane. Please take this food.” The Brahmachāri was shocked that this lady knew about the incident with the crane.



Seeing the shock on his face, the lady calmly added, “My Son, I prioritised my duty, which is to feed my tired husband. You don’t seem to know anything about yoga or spirituality yet. You have a wrong assumption about it. I don’t have time to teach you. So I suggest you go to the next village and seek the guidance of a person called **Dharmavyādha**. He will teach you Vedic yoga and the real essence of spirituality.

This hurt his ego, especially because a lady who hasn’t read the Vedas, read his mind and suggested him to seek the

Dharmic Insights of a Butcher

guidance of another man. Humbled, the young man went to the next village. He asked a few people about Dharmavyādha. They looked at him very quizzically and they showed him the way. Finally, he reached Dharmavyādha's place and was astounded to see a butcher.

The place looked just like an ordinary slaughterhouse with an overpowering stench of blood and meat hanging in front of the shop. While the Brahmachāri was studying the place, the butcher came out and said, "Son! Did the lady send you here? Come in". This further shook the Brahmachāri and he thought, "How did the butcher know about the lady?" The butcher with a smile told him, "Come in, I will teach you". By now, his ego was completely smashed. Dharmavyādha welcomed the Brahmachāri to his place. He then saw Dharmavyādha busy with attending to his parents. All this while, the young man was waiting and watching what Dharmavyādha was doing.

Mystified by all these unexpected experiences, the ascetic asked him why, in spite of his great wisdom, he was doing this gruesome work of a butcher. The butcher replied, "My son, you thought running into a forest and acquiring powers through meditation can make you an accomplished man! Well, you are wrong. You are sinned by killing the crane. You killed the crane because you were blind with anger and had no control over your mind or actions. This is not spirituality."

The man's ego was completely wiped out hearing this.

Dharmavyādha continued, "My son, no duty is ugly, no duty is impure. My birth placed me in these circumstances and environments. I learned this trade in my boyhood: I am unattached, and I try to do my duty well. I do all I can to make my father and mother happy."

Vyādha Gīta starts with the butcher teaching the Brahmacāri about how to worship one's work no matter what it is. He taught him that disinterest in work will reflect in the performance of duties.

This story actually comes in the Vana Parva, when the Pāṇḍavas are in the forest.

In Mahābhārata, Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa says that by considering work as worship, one can attain supremacy. People like King Janaka have attained supremacy through karma yoga - by considering their actions as worship. The butcher and the lady showed the Brahmacāri their devotion to their duties. The woman whole-heartedly served her husband and the butcher served his old parents with utmost reverence, without expecting any reward. They considered it as their duty and simply did it as an offering to the absolute. This has made them attain their goal. So the Butcher told the Brahmacāri, "You need to go back to your home, and take care of your parents first".

Swāmi Vivekānanda says the Vyādha Gīta contains the heights of the Advaita philosophy which propagates the idea of renunciation. When the all pervading self, the true reality is constantly within us, renunciation is not all about going

Dharmic Insights of a Butcher

away from the house, taking shelter in a forest, and becoming an ascetic. One can be a householder yet engage in spiritual endeavour. Ramaṇa Maharṣi says that one can change from a householder to an ascetic. But the point is to find out who the "I" is and to go beyond it.

A lady once requested Ammā to give her "enlightenment" or realisation. Ammā smiled at her and said, "Continue doing whatever you are doing, you will reach there one day".

She told her that the Yajña conducted by King Dakṣa turned into a battleground due to his audacity, whereas, with his dedication and faith in Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa, Arjuna turned the Kurukṣetra battleground into a place of worship.

The Brahmin in the story was undergoing the so-called spiritual austerities and was doing so with the ego that ended up pushing him into the pit of ignorance. Spirituality is not about running away from one's actions, or avoiding the basic duties and bindings of human existence. Just by serving their family with devotion, sense of duty, and complete detachment to any reward, the lady and the butcher become good examples of Karma Yoga.

Chapter 5

UNBROKEN LEGACY

Whether we realize or not, we live in the lustre of the lattice created by this Itihāsa. Observe carefully and we find that multitude of things around us are linked to this grand work.

We are but the chains of the unbroken legacy of Mahābhārata.



Chapter 5

THE UNBROKEN LEGACY

Mahābhārata portrays the complexities of human life, like sequences of images on a grand canvas. Composed by Maharṣi Veda Vyāsa thousands of years ago, it has played a major role in preserving the culture of our Nation. It has prominently influenced the philosophy and ethos of this land. Today, every society takes pride in tracing its history to Mahābhārata.

This module explores the various traditions associated with Mahābhārata across different parts of India. Further, a revelation of the Itihāsa's impact on India at large is also presented. We can see that Mahābhārata has spread across this land through rituals, storytelling, theatre, songs, folk performances, literature, etc. alongside its textual traditions.

Impact of Mahābhārata on Indian Literature

The storyline of Mahābhārata is familiar to everyone in India, from the intellectual to the illiterate. The daily incidents in their lives pull examples of the characters and stories from

this grand Itihāsa in a natural yet meaningful way. One reason for this popularity is the presence of different regional retellings of Mahābhārata, and the literary works that have been inspired by the Itihāsa.

Some of the regional versions of Mahābhārata are,

Malayālam

Mahābhāratam Kilippāttu by Śrī. Thunchath Ezhuthachan.

Cherusseri Bhāratam by Cherusseri

Bhāratmāla by Niranath Sankara Panicker.

Tamil

Mahābhārata by Peruntevanār and Villibhāratham by Villiputhūrān.

Odia

Mahābhārata by Sarala Dās.

Bengālī

Mahābhārata by Kabi Saṅjay.

Hindī

Mahābhārata by Sabal Singh Chauhan.

Assamese

Mahābhārata by Rāma Saraswati.

Besides these, Mahābhārata has been the focal centre for many literary works in various languages and literary genres. Three of the Pañcamahākāvyaś (Five great poems) of Samskr̥tam are rooted in Mahābhārata. Further, Kālidāsa's

Abhijñānaśākuntalam is a Samskr̥tam play based on the story of Śakuntalā and King Duṣyanta in Ādi Parva of Mahābhārata. Even before Kālidāsa there was Bhāsa, who wrote seven plays Bālacaritam, Karṇabhāram, Ūrubhaṅgam, Madhyamavyāyogam, Pañcarātram, Dūtakhatotkacham and Dūtavākyaṃ, all based on Mahābhārata.

In the Vana Parva, Arjuna worships Bhagavān Parameśvara himself, to attain the Pāśupatāstra, a powerful arrow named Pāśupata. Bhagavān approaches Arjuna as a Kirāta (Hunter/Gatherer) and tests him. Finally, he is pleased with Arjuna and gives him Pāśupata. Bhāṛavi, a poet of the sixth Century CE, wrote the Mahākāvya 'Kirātārjunīyam' based on this context. In another instance, in the Vana Parva of Mahābhārata, Muni Bṛhadaśva narrates the story of King Nala of the Kingdom of Niṣādas, to console the Pāṇdavās who were wandering in the forest after losing their kingdom. Śrīharṣa, in the twelfth Century CE, wrote the Mahākāvya Naiṣadha Cārithaṃ (Naiṣadha Cāritha) based on this story of King Nala.

Almost all the characters in the Itihāsa have faced inner conflicts rather than with others. This has beautifully portrayed the inevitable consequences of one's own Karma. Everyone can easily relate to these incidents with their own experiences. In this manner, different versions of Mahābhārata have played a vital role in giving new insights to people about life and living. Thus, Mahābhārata has served as a moral guide for the people of this nation over generations.

Festivals Associated with Mahābhārata

When festivals are celebrated in India, it is always imbued with charm and a sense of purpose. The ritualistic and ceremonial functions of festivals reflect the prosperity of a community. Some festivals are connected with the worship of the deity. Fasting and feasting are also part of the celebration [1]. Festivals help people to invoke various deities, which helps them in their spiritual upliftment.

Let us now closely look at some of the different festivals associated with Mahābhārata.

Karaga Festival is celebrated in Karnātaka annually, in the month of Caitra (March / April), chiefly by the Tigala community. The Tigalas consider themselves descendants of Draupadī. Śrī Dharmarāya Swāmi Temple in Bengaluru is the principal ritual centre of the Karaga festival. Spread over eleven days, Bengaluru Karaga essentially celebrates nature and water as is evident from the Gaṅgā Pūja ritual (worship of Goddess Gaṅgā) [2].

Kuvākam Festival is based on a story from one of the regional versions of Mahābhārata in Tamil Nādu. It focuses on one of the three boons granted to Arjuna's son Irāvān, or Arāvāṇ, by Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa, in honour of his self-sacrifice. Irāvān wanted to get married before his death. Bhagavān granted him this boon by taking the female form of Mohinī and marrying him. The next day, Arāvāṇ sacrificed his life and Mohinī grieved like a widow [3]. This festival is celebrated at the Śrī Kūttāṇṭavar Temple located in Villupuram District, Tamil Nādu.

Dhungrī Mela is celebrated on the birthday of Hiḍimbā Devī, who is a 'Rākṣasī' being in Mahabharata, married to Bhīma. It is commemorated at the Hiḍimbā Devī Temple at Manāli in the Indian state of Himāchal Pradesh. This temple is dedicated to Hiḍimbā (Hiḍimbī) Devī. The temple sanctum sanctorum is a cave shrine believed to have foot imprints of Hiḍimbā. Manāli is perhaps the only place in India where Hiḍimbā is worshipped as a goddess [4]. This festival is also known as Hiḍimbā Devī Mela.

Bhīṣma Ekādaśī is celebrated by people in the month of Māgha (Jan / Feb), in honour of Bhīṣma Pitāmaha, the great son of King Śāntanu and Gaṅgā Devī.

Chṭha Puja is one of the major festivals of Bihār which is dedicated to the worship of Sūrya Deva. Devotees perform



this Pūjā to thank the Sun for supporting life and seek protection and blessings. According to folklore, it is believed that Draupadī performed Chaṭha Pūjā during their years in exile.

Temples Associated with Mahābhārata

In Indian Culture, a temple or devālaya is the abode of a deity or Deva. People visit a temple to see or seek the Darśan of the deity who lives there. Devālayas or Temples play a major role in our life, culturally and spiritually. Temples help us alleviate suffering and help unfold the divinity within each of us. Let us learn about some major temples that are associated with Mahābhārata.

Pañca Pāṇḍava Temples in Kerala are five temples in the Cēnnannūr area. It is believed that each temple was built by one of the Pāṇḍavās. Devotees are supposed to start their pilgrimage with the Tṛccittāṭṭ Mahāviṣṇu Temple built by Yudhiṣṭhira. Then they seek Darśan from the Tṛppuliyūr Mahāviṣṇu Temple built by Bhīma, Āraṇmuḷa Pārthasārathy Temple built by Arjuna, Thiruvandoor Mahāviṣṇu Temple by Nakula and the Tṛkoṭittānam Mahāviṣṇu Temple by Sahadeva.

Some other temples related to Mahābhārata are:

- Pāñcālī Amman Temple, Pālakkād, Kerala.
- Śrī Pūrṇatrayīśa Temple, Tṛppūñittūr, Kerala: It is believed that the Vighraha (idol) of Pūrṇatrayīśa was given to Arjuna by Bhagavān Viṣṇu [5].

- Malanaḍa Duryodhana Temple, Kollam, Kerala.
- Gāndhārī Amman Temple, Tiruvananthapuram, Kerala.
- Pañca Pāṇḍava Temple, Gaṇeśwarpur, Odisha.
- Karṇā Temple, Netwar, Uttarākhand.
- Temple of Bhīṣma, Narkātārī, Haryānā.
- Draupadī Amman Temple, Véláchérī, Tamil Nādu.
- Śrī Dharmarāya Svāmi Temple, Beṅgalūru, Karnāṭaka.
- Hiḍimbā Devī Temple, Manāli, Himāchal Pradeś.
- Pañca Pāṇḍava Temple, Khammam, Telangānā

There are numerous Draupadī temples in south India, especially Tamil Nādu. In Tamil Nādu alone, there are hundreds of versions of Mahābhārata in the form of folklore [6].

Ancient Indian Hand Painting

Kalamkāri is a painted or block-printed cotton or silk fabric produced mainly in parts of Āndhra Pradesh and Tamil Nādu. Two of the most prominent centres of Kalamkāri production are Śrīkālahastī, Cīṭṭūr District, and Macilipataṇam, Kṛṣṇa District in Āndhra Pradesh [7]. The Śrīkālahastī Kalamkāri style involves the depiction of scenes from our Itihāsās, Mahābhārata, and Rāmāyana. It is interesting to know that the depictions of Mahābhārata scenes are even found in fabric.

There is an interesting belief in the Kalamkāri community that the Hanumān flag on the chariot of Arjuna was made in Kalamkāri style.

Various Art forms

India has a rich cultural legacy with multiple traditions, including a multitude of performing arts. Some traditions worship the Mahābhārata characters as deities and perform their stories as a devotional offering to them. Let us have a look at some of the art forms which are shaped by Mahābhārata.

Pāṇḍav Līlā in Garhwal region (Uttarākhand) is one such ritualistic performance that celebrates the characters of



Pāṇḍav Līlā

Mahābhārata. Pāṇḍav līlā is not an annual fixed affair, it is staged to offset bad omens and seek blessings of the Pāṇḍavās for peace and prosperity. Pāṇḍavās, in their quest to relive the glory of their past, bless the village, which gives them a chance to re-enact the various scenes of Mahābhārata [8].

Terukūtt is a rural folk theatre of Tamil Nādu. In a ritualistic performance, it enacts the characters of Mahābhārata. Villiputtūrār's version of Mahābhārata in Tamil is the main text upon which kūthu performances are based even today.



Terukūtt

Kathakali is a classical traditional theatre of Keralā, that is several centuries old. It is an enactment of stories, mostly from Mahābhārata. It is presented using gestures and well-defined facial expressions, alongside a blend of dance and music.



Kathakali

Kūṭiyāṭṭam is an ancient temple theatre in Keralā. It is one of the traditional performing art forms and has its episodes entirely drawn from Mahābhārata.



Kūṭiyāṭṭam

Chākyār kūthu is a performance that includes satire and social criticism. In the olden days, Chākyār (narrator) could even criticise the king during the kūthu.



Chākyār Kūthu

Bhaona is a traditional theatrical performance in upper and central parts of Assām often featuring stories from Mahābhārata.



Bhaona

Chhau dance is another old and popular tradition giving continuity to Mahābhārata. It is popular in Bengāl, Bihār and Oḍiṣā. Chhau is taught to male dancers from families of traditional artists or from local communities. The dance is performed at night in an open space to traditional and folk melodies, played on the reed pipes mohurī and shehnāi [9].



Chhau Dance

Vēlakālī is a martial dance, in which the dancers hold a sword and a shield in their hands. It depicts a fight sequence



Vēlakāḷi

between the Pāṇḍavās and the Kauravās [10]. It is usually performed in temples during festivals [11].

We can see that all the art forms that we have discussed so far have grown and developed on stories from Mahābhārata. This great Itihāsā is an unlimited source of stories and sub-stories. It is a Kalpavrikṣa (the wish-fulfilling divine tree), providing everything necessary for artists and writers. Mahābhārata itself says that the Itihāsās is a livelihood for them.

In addition to this, the contemporary entertainment industry also draws heavily from Mahābhārata themes. Starting from Peter Brook's Mahābhārata to the recently announced Telugu movie Virāṭa Parva, Mahābhārata is a perennial source of themes for films and dramas worldwide.

Anthropological information in Mahābhārata

Mahābhārata is a mine of anthropological information. It presents numerous kingdoms, dynasties, languages, cultures,

people, and regions. Mahābhārata lists three hundred and sixty-three Janās or jātis on different occasions [12]. The two terms, jana and jāti (from the root 'ja', meaning born or descended from), are broadly interchangeable, but the former refers more to a people forming a state, while the latter connotes a community of people or a segment of a Jana.

- Janās in the North (Northern Himālayan Region): Trigartās, Khāsās etc. Jammū has numerous traditions related to Mahābhārata. Some of the tribals there worship Pāṇḍavās and Draupadī as Iṣṭa Devatā (as their favourite deity)
- Janās in the South: Cholās, Pāṇḍyās, Drāvidās, Keralās, Āndhrās etc.
- Janās in the West: Yādavās, Surāṣṭrās, Vahilkās, etc.
- Janās in the Northwest: Yavanās, Kambojās, Sakās, etc.
- Janās in the East: Angās, Kirātās, Vangās, Chinās, and Pundrās. Kirātās correspond to the Indo-Mongoloids of the Northeast. There is a tradition that identifies Ghaṭotkaca with the Kacāri kingdom in Assām [13].

Influence in Architecture

The architectural expression of devotion scaled new heights with carvings based on Mahābhārata in various places. The representation of Mahābhārata on the wall in the form of visuals has inspired the masses and has become a bridge between the scriptures and innocent minds [14]. From the

majestic Mahābhārata carvings at Hoyesāleśwara Temple, Karnāṭaka and the epitome of architectural perfection 'Arjuna's Penance' at Mahābalipuram, Tamil Nādu to the intricate sculpture of the Pāṇḍavās and Draupadī at the Daśāvatāra Temple at Deogarh, Rājasthān, we can see the luxuriousness of Indian architecture influenced by Mahābhārata.



Arjuna's Penance, Rock-Cut Relief, Mahabalipuram

Scenes from this Itihāsa have been depicted in Kailāsa Temple, Ellora, Amriteswarā Temple, Karnāṭaka; Mallikāṛjuna Temple, Pattadakal; Ambā thīrtha, Karnāṭaka; Narasiṃha Temple, Mysore; Keśav Temple, Somnāthpur, and in many other temples and palaces all over India.¹⁵

Interestingly, Ammā, Sat-guru Śrī Mātā Amritānandamayī Devī, also chose a scene from Mahābhārata as the primary sculpture in the Kālī temple at Her Āśram in Amṛtapurī. This is a depiction of Arjuna in a chariot with Bhagavān

Śrī Kṛṣṇa as a charioteer, in a charging mode. Ammā might be symbolising the 'rejuvenated Arjuna who fights to re-establish Dharma'. And through this sculpture, Ammā might be requesting us to do the same.

Conclusion

Everything we discussed now is just the tip of the iceberg. There are plenty more spheres of existence where this grand Itihāsa has demonstrated its stupendous impact. Names of people and places, influence on language, ethics, and an endless list of things. Undoubtedly, this Itihāsa has seeped into the psyche of the Indian subcontinent. The more we learn about Mahābhārata, the more we perceive the depth of impact. Even in portraying characters and their behaviours, we would perhaps find a close similarity to those living around us. Only then that we turn absolutely speechless, bowing down to the genius of Maharṣi Vyāsa. Only then do we truly appreciate the unbroken legacy of this monumental work in its entirety!

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Chapter 6

**A TIMELESS ITIHĀSA FOR
TIMELY NEEDS**

Verily, this text is both timely and timeless, for it traverses the ages and illuminates the path ahead.

How can a timeless Itihāsa serve for our timely needs? Will you dare to delve into its depths and discover?



Chapter 6

A TIMELESS ITIHĀSA FOR TIMELY NEEDS

Mahābhārata is known as one of the national epics of India. When we say Itihāsa, it is something different from an epic. Itihāsa is a huge body of literature - an organic body of literature with a historical core, the sanctum, with a spiritual nucleus. Most of the time when people study a particular epic like Mahābhārata, especially during the last two hundred years, there has been a tendency to look at it through a westernised academic framework. Because of that, we have lost our grasp of the essence of the epic. We always move about in the periphery and start to believe that the periphery is the core.

Consider, for example, a scholar of Shakespeare whom we would call the scholar of the bard. A person who has studied all his dramas and internalised the value system of Shakespeare. Suppose there is another researcher who studies the chemical nature of Shakespeare's ink. That too

is a study of the bard. We clearly understand that the latter is only the periphery. Here the demarcation is very clear. How would we take it when such a person makes a statement on the value system of Shakespeare? Would we consider that an authoritative statement?

In the case of India, our national epics were studied by scholars of the periphery. And they passed judgement as if they were the scholars of the core. And we failed to realise that they were not the authorities. And to add to the misery and tragedy, we have ignored the long line of scholars in India who understood the periphery as well as the core, the scholars who internalised the core, the sages and seers who lived the core, who made their own life the message of the itihāsa. We have ignored all that, and accepted the periphery scholars as the scholars of the Itihāsa. Hence now we have studies based on the flimsiest framework through which Mahābhārata may be approached, the subaltern studies of the Mahābhārata, the ethnological studies of Mahābhārata, etc.

There is a famous fable of a fox. The fox wanted to measure the depth of the ocean. One day the fox decided to go to the ocean. It thought, "Everyone is talking about how the ocean is so great and how no one can measure its depth. I want to see for myself if they are telling the truth." When it reached the ocean and saw the giant waves repeatedly crashing against the shore, it grew apprehensive. It was not as sure as before. Slowly it moved towards the water and dipped its tail. It was standing on the shore with the waves, so there was



the illusion that it was standing in the ocean. It dipped its tail and touched the ground. The fox realised something. It came and announced, “I know the depth of the ocean. It is only three-fourths the length of my tail.”

This is exactly the state of the scholars who apply the Freudian framework, the subaltern framework, or the postmodern

framework to study Mahābhārata. Mahābhārata doesn't fit in these kinds of frameworks. Such scholars are like young students standing before a great sculpture, not knowing what to do. They have never been taught to appreciate it. And what do they do when standing before something so great and magnificent? They scribble their name there. That is the only response they can give. Many academicians do the same thing. They scribble their name down. They try to deface the great work and then announce to the world that they too have contributed.

So, how do we study Mahābhārata? Suppose I am an environmentalist, and I want to study Mahābhārata from an environmentalist point of view. Am I wrong? No. But it is absurd to insist that this is the only framework. It is wrong to conclude that the Mahābhārata can be understood only through this value system. What else should we do? Instead of standing on the shore and dipping our tails in the water, we should have the courage to dive into the ocean and pick the pearls from its depths. It is the 'diving deep' that we have to look into.

With this in our mind, let us look into certain aspects of Mahābhārata and see what kind of pearls we can take for our timely needs. Again, remember that Mahābhārata can provide for our timely needs but Mahābhārata itself is timeless. It is Sanātana and it can give solutions to our ephemeral needs, to our pressing problems of the day.

Consider as an example, the problem of untouchability. What framework can we use here? What kind of things

do we have to study here? Untouchability is essentially a disease of the mind. How do we cure this? Let us turn to Bhagavadgītā in Mahābhārata. Let us see what kind of pearls we can pick from Mahābhārata pertaining to this particular problem. Here, a kind of healing auśadha can be taken from Mahābhārata and applied to this particular wound of society.

अहङ्कारं बलं दर्पं काम क्रोधं च संश्रिताः ।

मामात्मपरदेहेषु प्रद्विषन्तोऽभ्यसूयकाः ॥

*Ahaṅkāraṁ balaṁ darpaṁ kāma krodhaṁ ca saṁśritāḥ |
māmātmaparadeheṣu pradviṣanto'bhyaśūyakāḥ ||*

Bhagavadgītā 16.18

Bhagavadgītā says very clearly that there are certain traits, asuric aspects in us. What are those aspects? Kṛṣṇa talks about five characteristics - Ahaṅkāra, Balaṁ, Darpaṁ, Kāmam, and Krodham. Then Bhagavān says that the person affected by these five aspects hates me as the Ātmā in his own body and in others' bodies.

This is very important. Bhagavān says there is hatred. The hatred is against the body of oneself and the body of others and ultimately, such a person hates oneself because he / she hates the Ātman. Then what are the reasons for the hatred? One is Ahaṅkāra - egoism. Then Balaṁ, the comfort of power, just power without any moral value, power for the sake of power. Our ego and our power both reinforce each other. Then we flaunt that power (Darpaṁ), showing off our ability to do these things. We have lust for resources (Kāmam), control of others, etc. We develop a kind of anger

(Krodham) towards others, a kind of hatred towards others. All these five can reinforce each other. The result is we start hating others. And in doing so we are expressing hatred for ourselves. Whenever a person hates another person, actually the person is hating himself. So, whenever a person treats another person as untouchable, he / she is actually harming himself / herself, harming one's own realisation of the ātman. Now, let us take this framework to a particular village. Let us study a particular conflict between the weak and dominant sections of society. We will realise that the person who indulges in exploitation or violence, irrespective of which community he / she belongs to, will have all these five elements in him / her. So, you have a framework here to understand your social problems. But providing this framework is not the purpose of Bhagavadgītā, nevertheless, it can provide you with the framework.

Consider a particular feminist who wants to develop a notion of the Indic feminine – an Indic point of view of a woman. What are the defining qualities of a woman in Indian tradition? She / he can find in Bhagavadgītā,

कीर्तिः श्रीर्वाक्च नारीणां स्मृतिर्मेधा धृतिः क्षमा ॥

"kīrtiḥ śrīr vāk cha nārīṇāṁ smṛitir Medhā dhṛitiḥ

Kṣamā"

Bhagavadgītā 10.34

These are the qualities that Śrī Kṛṣṇa says are feminine qualities. These feminine qualities are actually emanations

from the divine. Now, what are all these qualities?

Kīrtiḥ – Usually in all the so-called patriarchal societies, all the so-called pre-modern societies, a woman is not supposed to have fame. A woman is presumed to be in the shadow of her husband. If she is going to have fame, it is because of the position of either her husband or her father. But here, Kṛṣṇa says that fame is one of the important defining qualities of a woman. And the quality is itself feminine.

Śri – Śri is not just wealth but auspicious wealth. What is auspicious wealth? Consider an example. If you look at the ordinary village accountants, ordinary village shopkeepers, they would first write ‘Śubh Lābh’ when they start to write the day’s accounts. For them, the Śubham always comes before the Lābham. The collective goodness of society comes before the profit. They want the profit, but the profit is always tempered by the need for collective goodness. So the wealth that is generated through Śubham and Lābham is Śri and that again is defined as the quality of a woman.

Vāk – This is an interesting aspect. It is telling the truth. Telling the truth in a sweet way, and also in such a way that it harms nobody, but benefits all. Tiruvalluvar explains, “Telling a word in such a way that there is no other word to counter it.” That is vāk. Vāk is something that is true. There are people who tell the truth just to hurt us. But Vāk is telling the truth with sweetness in such a way that it will not hurt anyone. If the truth is really true, it will not hurt anyone. It may shake the beliefs of certain people but ultimately it will

bring hitam – it will bring goodness to the self. Telling such words is again a defining quality of a woman and it is itself a feminine quality.

Smṛiti – Memory or very good memory is another very important strength in a woman.

Medhā – Genius or insightful genius. We always talk about feminine intuition – the feminine insight of others. To understand this better, let us look at the kind of approaches Science had when it was male-dominated and what changed when women started contributing. One good example is Jane Goodall. You may recall that she gave the Gandhi King Award to Amma, Sat-guru Śrī Mātā Amṛitanandamayī Devī sometime back.

Jane Goodall was the person who discovered that chimpanzees could make tools. When she wrote her paper on chimpanzees, she referred to chimpanzees as individual personalities – not as ‘it’ but as ‘he’ or ‘she’. Science was not ready to accept that. Science said that when you are mentioning chimpanzees you have to mention ‘it’. To this, she replied, “No – I see them as personalities and will refer to them as he or she.” Her kind empathy, boldness and her keen ability to observe these traits in chimpanzees are inspiring.

There have been many daring male explorers to Africa. They were not able to see chimpanzees making tools or a personality in them. In fact, they considered the guerillas as mere beasts. But Jane Goodall was able to see their personality. This is insightful genius. There are many other examples of

feminine scientists who have brought in such insight. And essentially 'insightful genius' is a feminine quality, according to Bhagavadgītā.

Dhṛitiḥ – A person with this quality takes decisions and sticks with it. An example comes from Mahābhārata itself, of Savitri. There are two beautiful stories in Mahābhārata one is that of Ruru – Priyaṃvada and another one is that of Satyavān and Savitri.

In the account of Ruru – Priyaṃvada, Priyaṃvada dies. Ruru makes a deal with Yama and brings Priyaṃvada back to life by giving half of his own life. Whereas in the case of Savitri, she was able to win over death and bring back her husband Satyavān.

Śrī Aurobindo has written a long poem on Ruru and Priyaṃvada, but he wrote an entire epic on Savitri. She was strong-willed. She stood steady in her decision. She was told that Satyavān would die. Savitri replied, "I am going to stand by him." When Satyavān died and Yama was taking his life, Savitri fought with Yama and brought Satyavān back to life.

Kṣamā – Forgiveness. Knowing their strength, women have been very forgiving to us. That is why society has been going well enough so far. Despite all our faults, our blunders, two world wars, and nuclear weapons, humanity is surviving because of their motherly patience.

So, these are the defining qualities of a woman that Śrī Kṛṣṇa gives. How many feminist schools employ these parameters to study how women interact with society or the value that

women bring to society?

These are the different aspects of Mahābhārata that we can look into and bring to the table so that society can take from Mahābhārata and apply it to their lives.

If you take Mahābhārata as a whole, you find again that it is not just a property dispute between two clans. It is a fight between good and evil. And there is a period when evil or the adharmic forces rule. They give a semblance of order. But, overall, an adharmic period is an adharmic period. After that comes the dharmic period, usually after a conflict.

Let us consider another aspect, national integration and managing and living with pluralism. How do we live with plurality? How do we live with diversity? In most cultures, the answer is to manage diversity in such a way that it is subjugated to the majoritarian point of view, majoritarian culture, the monoculture that is dominant. That did not happen in India. In India, there is no such thing as majoritarian culture. In India, there is one grand cultural matrix. And that matrix contains a lot of strands of different colours. And there is resistance when a particular strand tries to dominate. Because in India there is theo-diversity and there is resistance to monocultural expansionism. And how do we understand this? How do we understand the different diversities? How do we relate to diversity? The answer is again given in Mahābhārata and Bhagavadgītā,

यदा भूतपृथग्भावमेकस्थमनुपश्यति ।

तत एव च विस्तारं ब्रह्म सम्पद्यते तदा ॥

*yadā bhūtaprthagbhāvamekasthamanupaśyati
tata eva ca vistāraṁ brahma sampadyate tadā*

Bhagavadgītā 13.31

The person who experiences the one becoming the many, and in the many the one, he is the one who gets to realise the Brahman.

You can see here, where we got the concept of unity in diversity. The unity present in diversity has been explained in Bhagavadgītā very explicitly. And it is this that has become the civilizational aspect of the cornerstone of India. In fact, this is the basic process throughout the Universe.

Consider this example. Schrödinger wrote a book called, 'What is Life?' He searched for the basic fundamental mechanism or the entity responsible for genetics and genetic diversity. You have something that maintains itself while being capable of producing diversity. In other words, a process that produces diversity from unity and it exists as unity in diversity. From 'What is life' you can actually draw a path to the discovery of DNA and its structure.

This particular insight has become the cornerstone of Science, particularly Biological Sciences, Ecological Sciences, and The Secrets of Life; that point was, for the first time, very clearly stated as a principle in the Bhagavadgītā. If a scientist understands Bhagavadgītā's insight, he can do better Science. If a carpenter understands the principles of

the Bhagavadgītā, then he can do better carpentry.

This is the greatness of Mahābhārata. It is an open text. It is a timely and timeless text. Let us not forget that ultimately it is a sacred text that aims at Mokṣa. It is a Mokṣa śāstra. And if we are going to concentrate only on the social, sociological, or ethnological aspects, then we are missing out on the core. We are only talking about the chemical composition of Shakespeare's ink. We are not talking about the play. You have to immerse yourself in Mahābhārata. You have to allow Mahābhārata to fill you with its fundamental values.

Chapter 7

PRATIJÑĀ

A brilliant example of the timely relevance!
Just as Bhīṣma, Bhīma, Gāndhārī, Arjuna, and
numerous other characters gave their solemn
words, so too have we. Was their commitment
worthwhile? Is it worth clinging onto? These
archetypes serve as a beacon of light, illuminating
our fleeting existence.





PRATIKA

will find example of the timely relevance
of the Bhagavad Gita. The Bhagavad Gita
and numerous other characters have their own
roles to play. We have their own
characters which is a work of art. These
characters are a person of light illuminating
our living existence.

Chapter 7

PRATIJÑĀ

Embarking on the journey of Mahābhārata is in itself experiencing the physical presence of the divine in our life. The accounts of Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa, Maharṣi Kṛṣṇa Dvaipāyana Vyāsa, Bhārgavarāma, Balarāmā, Devavrata-Bhīṣma or Maharṣi Animāndavyā, among many more, are awe-inspiring moments of reading. When Devavrata makes that fierce and terrible vow, the skies thunder with the voices of the Gods, “Bhīṣma... Bhīṣma...”. When the Pāṇḍavas are born, all the devas appear in the sky and shower them with blessings and flowers (Whereas when Duryodhana is born, a donkey brays outside, and the minister suggests that this being a bad sign, he should be abandoned then and there to save the kingdom).

Animāndavyā Muni, mistaken to be part of a group of thieves, gets caught by the King's soldiers, and is punished. He bears the pain of being held up on a spear to the spine, without dying, while the other thieves die. The king realises

his mistake later, and releases him, yet the spear could not be removed. And he lives out his life with the spear still intact. When finally he reaches the abode of Yama-Dharma, Yamadeva himself gets cursed by Animāndavyā Muni for misinterpreting Dharma, which led to this ill fate. Even Dharmadeva himself is not above Dharma.

Mahābhārata presents to us, logic, decisions, contexts, characters, feelings, and emotions, that are complex to figure out. A student of this grand Itihāsa is forced to grind and churn his heart and mind, which itself becomes a process that earns an understanding of Dharma.

In the Ādi Parva, Devavrata spontaneously decides and proclaims the Bhīṣhma-Pratijñā, and becomes Bhīṣhma. And we began to wonder if it was the right thing to do. Surely, it was not the case that his father Śāntanu's life depended on it. The future of the kingdom did not depend on it! His own life too did not depend on it! The Pratijñā only catered to his father's kāma.

Devavrata, appointed yuvarāja of the Kuru dynasty, learns of his father's love for Satyawatī. To marry her, Śāntanu must fulfil Satyawatī's father's conditions, which include making Satyawatī's son the next king. Śāntanu rejects this proposal. But later Devavrata accepts, without seeking counsel. To make this happen he takes a lifelong vow of Brahmacharya and renounces his claim to the throne. He earns the name Bhīṣhma, 'the one of the Terrible Vow', and the power to choose the time of his death. As we begin learning Mahābhārata, we are

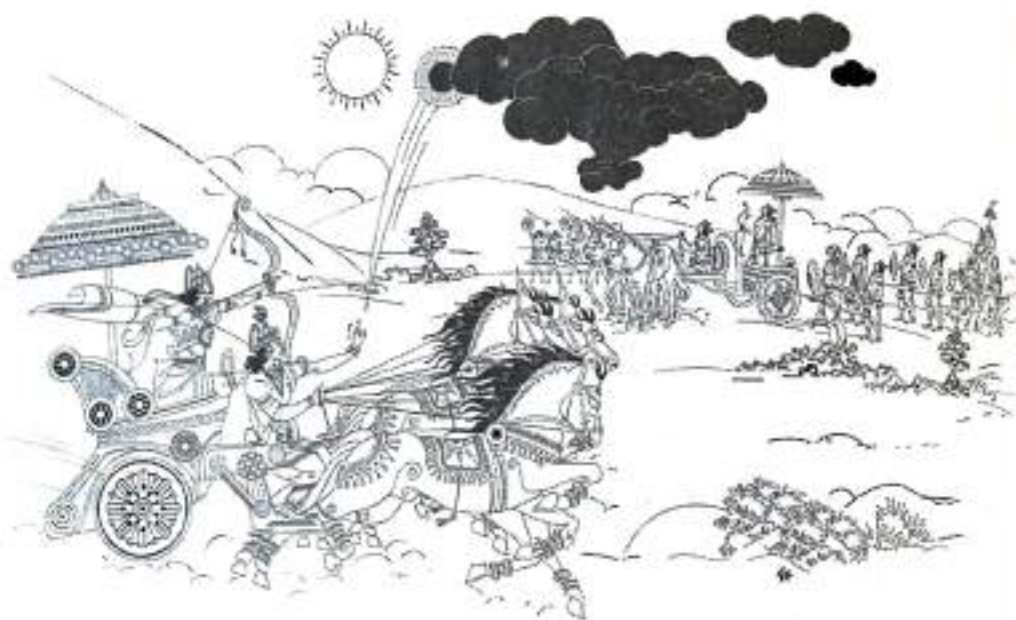
thrust into finding logic and reason here, weighing the need for such a pratijñā against its consequences.

This decision to renounce a key administrative post without notice or consultation raises questions about its Dharma. As Yuvarāja, didn't Devavrata have a higher responsibility to seek his father's permission? What was the drive behind Bhīṣma's decision to take this lifelong vow of celibacy, without any thought for its impact on the kingdom? How could Bhīṣma be certain that Satyawatī would bear children? And if she did, would they be capable of becoming morally and intellectually qualified kings?

Satyawatī does give birth to two sons. But ironically, both of them passed away without having any children. The younger son, Vicitravīrya, died leaving behind two widows, Ambikā and Ambālikā. As per the Vedic tradition, a widow of an heirless king is allowed to bear a child with a suitable surrogate. Satyawatī asks Bhīṣma to do it. And she even asks him to take the throne and be king. Bhīṣma disagreed to both proposals.

Here we wonder again. Śāntanu has died. Satyawatī's children too have died. The only person who is left behind, who is a stakeholder to the Bhīṣma-pratijñā is Satyawatī. And she is proposing that Bhīṣma forfeit his vow, and take back the kingdom. Satyawatī may have been ambitious before, in wanting to be the rājamātā. Bhīṣma's vow ensured this. But now even Satyawatī is able to see that it was all in vain. She embraced the intelligent way out of this predicament. Yet Bhīṣma rejects! Why? For whose benefit?

Maharṣi Vyāsa, another son of Satyavatī, fathered children with the widows, leading to the birth of Dhṛtarāṣṭra, Pāṇḍu, and Vidura. Adding to the previous irony, both Dhṛtarāṣṭra and Pāṇḍu were considered unfit to be the King. And another was born, Vidura, but to a maid. Though he was exemplary, he too could not be the King. Pāṇḍu was chosen and he ruled well, only to die too soon, with heirs not old enough. The throne is left empty yet again.



This throne finds a stable king only at the end of the Kurukṣetra war. Though Yudhiṣṭira becomes king in between, he is unseated by Duryodhana's wicked plots. Now one has to wonder, "Was this pratijñā so important?" How many people may have suffered from this continued kinglessness? In the end, 18 akṣauhiṇīs of soldiers died in battle.

This much hailed Pratijñā, has many nuances. On the one hand, it is a tremendous feat, impossible for most men. Even Ārjuna couldn't keep to his twelve year Brahmacharya, when he was exiled for walking in on Yudhiṣṭira and Draupadī. The sharp contrast to Bhīṣma's brahmacharya is his own father's weakness that drew him to Satyawatī. We also see how King Mahābhīṣā (who was born as Śāntanu as per Bhagavān Brahma's instruction) was drawn to Gaṅgādevī as well. Hence there is no doubt that Bhīṣma is the Brahmacharya archetype of Mahābhārata.

Such strength and willpower could have taken Bhāratavarṣa a long way, had it been used for the needs of the kingdom. Unfortunately, we can only imagine how the kingdom could have been had Devavrata ruled as king. Bound by his Pratijñā, Bhīṣma became powerless even before a blind king and his son.

Bhīṣma is indeed the archetype of a Brahmachari in Mahābhārata. But is he the archetype of Dharma or Pratijñā? When our vows contradict Dharma, what should we do? Let us explore Mahābhārata further for the Pratijñā archetype.

We focus on the vows taken by a few characters from Mahābhārata - Gāndhārī, Ārjuna, and Bhīma. We will study the circumstances under which the Pratijñās were taken and the consequences that followed. We will also draw a parallel to our present-day lives, understanding the Pratijñās we take.

Gāndhārī's Pratijñā

Gāndhārī was the daughter of King Subala from Gandhāradeśa. King Subala had many sons, the eldest being

Śakuni. Bhīṣma was in search of a suitable bride for the blind prince Dhṛtarāṣṭra. When he heard of Princess Gāndhārī, he sent a messenger to King Subala asking for his daughter's hand in marriage to Dhṛtarāṣṭra. King Śubala hesitated at first as Prince Dhṛtarāṣṭra was blind. However, he later agreed considering the greatness of the Kurus and Bhīṣma.

Gāndhārī, on hearing that her parents had arranged her marriage to the blind Dhṛtarāṣṭra, picked up a piece of cloth and blindfolded herself. As her husband was blind, she decided resolutely that she would never experience more than her husband could. Such was her dedication towards her husband that she chose to stand behind him in every sense.

This act of hers has received plentiful praise. But was it the right choice? Modern-day scholars raise a pertinent question, whether the most important thing in a marriage is the evenness of the husband and wife or their compatibility. Shouldn't both partners complement each other as they walk the householder's life?

No matter how much we eulogise her, this hasty Pratijñā certainly has had deep repercussions. Duryodana's stubbornness and inflated ego were never corrected and improper parenting had the lion's share of contribution in the upbringing of some of the most unprincipled characters of the Itihāsa. The choice to keep her eyes closed also has an inner connotation - to turn a blind eye to all the activities done by her sons. Undeniably, the role of the mother is paramount when raising children. The situation might have

been different if she had not blindfolded herself, and become the eyes for her husband instead.

Amma says, “The principle of motherhood is as vast and powerful as the universe. With the power of motherhood within her, a woman can influence the entire world”. In Gāndhārī’s case, we see her failing to influence her children for the better. Her Pratijñā to remain blindfolded arose not from the clarity of thinking but more from an instantaneous emotional response, at an age when she would have had relatively less understanding about the essence, purpose, and comprehensiveness of marriage.

Arjuna’s Pratijñā

Arjuna’s Pratijñā was to kill Jayadratha before sunset. During the Kurukṣetra war, Arjuna’s son Abhimanyu was killed on the thirteenth day, which led to this vow.

Droṇācārya constructed a deadly army formation called Cakravyūha. The Pāṇḍavas planned that Abhimanyu would penetrate the army formation, while the other warriors would follow and protect him. But King Jayadratha’s unexpected interference prevented the rest of the Pāṇḍava warriors from entering the Cakravyūha. Abhimanyu, however, breached the army formation and killed Duryodhana’s son and many other princes. Sadly, breaking all the ethics of Dharmayuddha, Abhimanyu was simultaneously attacked by many powerful warriors of Duryodhana’s army. He was killed by a final blow from Duhśāsana son. When Arjuna learned of his son’s death, he was filled with anger, and he pledged that he would kill Jayadratha the very next day before sunset.

Duryodhana, on hearing Arjuna's Pratijñā, consulted his advisors to come up with a plan to prevent Arjuna from killing Jayadratha in battle. Droṇācārya arranged a combination of three vyūhas (military formations) in order to protect Jayadratha from Arjuna. Bhīma, Sātyaki, and Arjuna tore through the Kaurava army but Jayadratha was hiding behind Droṇācārya, and it became very evident that Arjuna would not be able to kill Jayadratha before sunset. But Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa came to his rescue. Bhagavān sent his Sudarśanacakra to mask the sun and create the illusion of sunset. Jayadratha came out thinking the sun had set and that the Pratijñā had been forfeited. Bhagavān withdrew his Sudarśanachakra, revealing the sun. Seizing this opportunity Arjuna picked up his Gāṇḍīva and killed Jayadratha with the Pāśupatāstra.

Here we can see, Arjuna's Pratijñā did not arise from clear thought. Rather it was an emotional response to the anger he felt, learning of his son's death by adharma. Meanwhile, the Kauravas had planned well to defend Jayadratha from Arjuna and they would have succeeded if it was not for Bhagavān's intervention.

Bhīma's Pratijñā

Duryodhana, influenced by his uncle Śakuni, invited the Pāṇḍavas for a game of dice. Śakuni resorted to deceit, defeated Yudhiṣṭhira, and won his possessions one by one. Yudhiṣṭhira lost everything; his army, kingdom, his brothers, and himself to Duryodhana and, finally even their wife

Draupadī.

As Draupadī was forcefully pulled by her hair into the sabhā, Duḥśāsana attempted to disrobe her, but she was saved by Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa. Bhīma, overflowing with rage, vowed to kill Duḥśāsana in war, to tear open his chest and drink his blood. Draupadī was further vilified by Karṇa and Duryodhana. Duryodhana taunted Draupadī by gesturing to her to come and sit on his thigh, indicating her servitude to him. Bhīma, infuriated, made a second Pratijñā that he would break Duryodhana's thigh in battle.

Like the other Pratijñā's we discussed so far, Bhīma too took these vows reacting to his emotions. However, these Pratijñās are markedly different - let us see how.

In Udyoga Parva, we see the Pāṇḍavas requesting their kingdom back from the Kauravas, as agreed in the 'Game of Dice'. Duryodhana however, refuses this request and all other requests made by the Pāṇḍavas. Though war seemed inevitable, Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa went as a peace messenger to the court of the Kauravas to negotiate a peaceful resolution to the conflict with Duryodhana. Kṛṣṇa consulted all the five Pāṇḍavas and Draupadī before his journey to meet Duryodhana. Surprisingly, Bhīma approved of peace rather than war, just like his elder brother Yudhiṣṭira. He was willing to forgo his Pratijñās to kill Duryodhana and Duḥśāsana. Here we see that he did not ponder the question of war or peace in light of the Pratijñā he made.

But, war became inevitable no matter how hard Bhagavān

tried. Bhīma fulfils his first Pratijñā, and kills Duḥśāsana in battle, without conflicting Dharma. Towards the end of the war, the Kaurava army was reduced to Duryodhana, Ashwatthāma, Kṛpa, and Kṛtavarma. When Duryodhana was given the option to choose any one of the Pāṇḍava warriors for a one-on-one battle, he picked Bhīma and suggested a mace fight. The fight continued for a long time and Bhīma started getting tired. Observing this, Kṛṣṇa signalled Bhīma to strike Duryodhana hard on his thigh and break it. Bhīma followed Bhagavān's instructions and defeated Duryodhana. Here we see that Bhīma chose to fight and defeat Duryodhana in full adherence to dharma. His Pratijñā to break Duryodhana's thigh does not interfere with his dharmic acumen. When he did break his thigh in the end, it was only to fulfil Bhagavān's instruction and not his Pratijñā. Though Bhīma ended up making Pratijñā's out of anger, he did not let it cloud his judgement or his decisions.

All three Pratijñās were emotionally based. Gāndhārī's Pratijñā, though considered noble, blinded her to the adharma of her children. This adharma grew day by day and eventually resulted in the bloodshed of the entire family alongside countless others. Arjuna's Pratijñā could have gotten him in a fix since he took the vow without any forethought. But thanks to Kṛṣṇa he could fulfil it. Bhīma while taking the Pratijñā was in an emotionally challenging situation but was willing to prioritise Dharma. This is evident from his opinion to opt for peace over war. It is also

evident from his battle with Duryodhana.

Don't we all take such Pratijñās in our daily lives when we find ourselves in some emotional situations? Sometimes consciously and sometimes subconsciously without even realising it, we take vows. "I won't talk to that person", silent treatments, "I won't do this or that anymore", etc. These are all different forms of Pratijñās.

Having taken such vows, there are two questions that we should contemplate.

The first one is whether we took the vow out of intellectual clarity or whether it was a spontaneous outburst in a demanding situation. If we took the Pratijñā as an emotional retort, then the second question after comprehending the bigger picture is whether there is any use in sticking to that Pratijñā. We should follow it if we still feel that the Pratijñā is beneficial for us or our society. Otherwise, shouldn't we drop it? Let us explore one more Pratijñā to understand.

Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa took a vow to not take up arms in the Kurukṣetra war. This was the condition he placed before Arjuna and Duryodhana. He said he would join on one side, and his army on the other, and that he would not carry or use weapons in battle. This led Duryodhana to take Śrī Kṛṣṇa's Yādava army. And Arjuna wholeheartedly welcomed Bhagavān to his side.

But in the war, Śrī Kṛṣṇa was forced to reconsider when Bhīṣma took a counter vow to make him do so. Bhīṣma's determination to destroy the Pāṇḍavas at any cost became

more and more apparent. And on the other side, Arjuna's reverence for Bhīṣma kept holding him back from attacking with his full capacity. Śrī Kṛṣṇa could no longer allow it.

With a chariot wheel in hand, Kṛṣṇa dashed towards Bhīṣma. It was only Arjuna's promise to fight to the best of his ability that pacified him. Śrī Kṛṣṇa spoke clearly to Bhīṣma, telling him that he was misusing his boon of choosing his hour of death against warriors who had no such mystical protection.

Here you find that Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa was not tied by his Pratijñā. It did not hold him back or make him hesitate. With clarity, he took to action answering the call of Dharma. Bhagavān himself is the Pratijñā archetype in Mahābhārata, revealing to us much more about Bhīṣma who trapped himself with his Pratijñā, unable to respond to adharma.





Chapter 8

KARṆA - THE MAESTRO WHO WENT WIDE OF THE MARK

Karṇa epitomizes the confluence of right and wrong, virtue and vice in human nature. Nevertheless, the path of Dharma is the only way forward - no shortcuts, no excuses. In Mahābhārata, we may find a part of ourselves in all the characters. Let us learn from their mistakes and avoid similar errors in our own lives.





Chapter 8

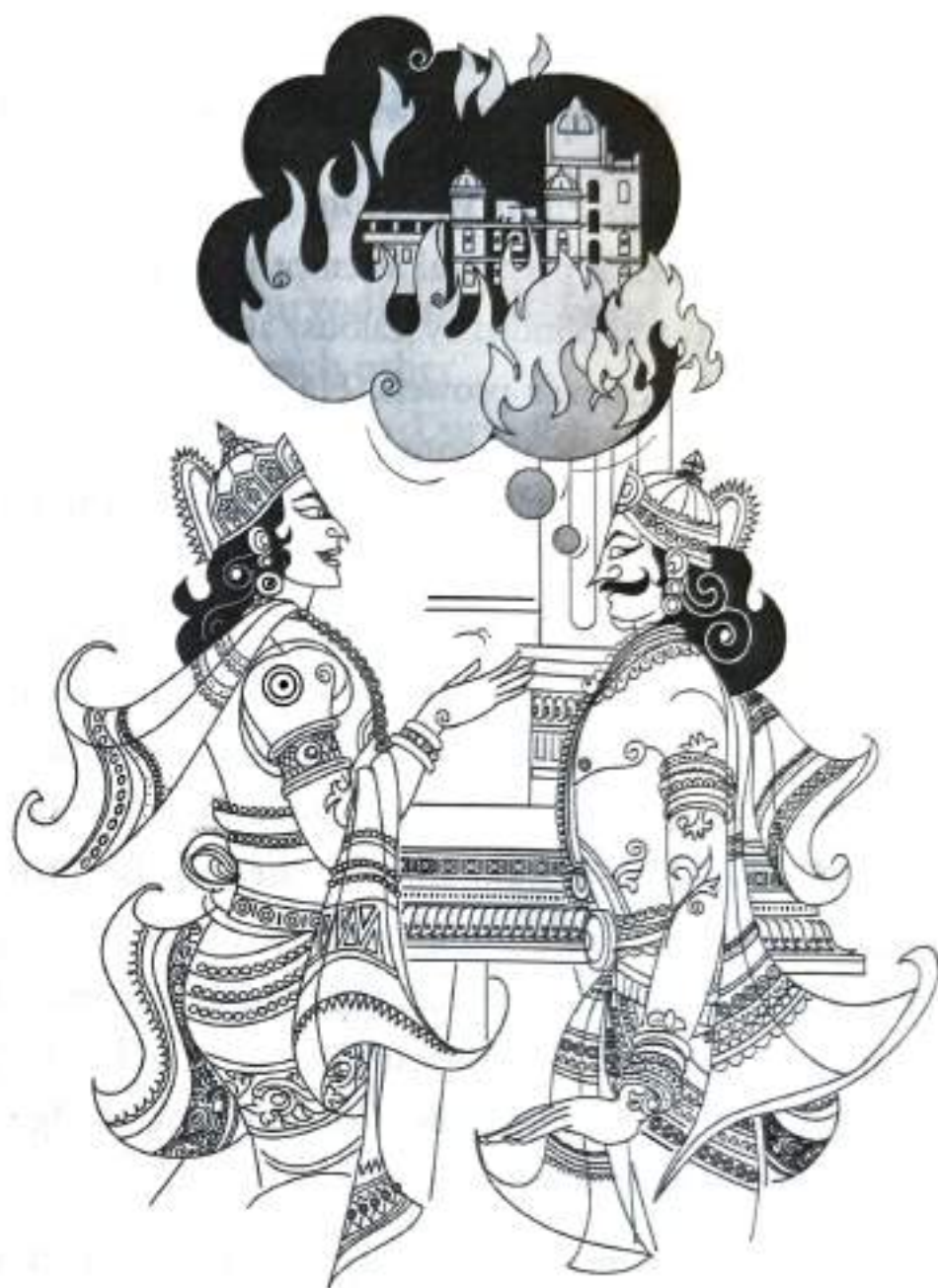
KARṆA: THE MAESTRO WHO WENT WIDE OF THE MARK

Karṇa has been one of the most debated characters in Mahābhārata. There are different versions of his story; hence, an overall understanding of his character has become vague. Literary works like Bhāsā's Karṇabhāram, Mṛtyunjaya by Śivajī Sawanth and other writers and scholars, "piece together from segments" where Karṇa becomes the main character (Hiltebeitel, 2011, p.484). There are a lot of explanations justifying Karṇa's fall from dhārmic ethics and principles, to unrighteousness and evil. Those who side with Karṇa claim his superiority over Arjuna in instances where the latter failed to resist the Nāgāstra on the seventeenth day of the Kurukṣetra battle (and Kṛṣṇa saving Arjuna). The fact is that in a war, even the mightiest warrior will have their moments of failure and Karṇa cannot be labelled as superior because of this. After all, he was not the only warrior who

caught Arjuna off-guard. The valiant Bhagadatta also did it. Kaṛṇa's defeat at the hands of Bhīma, Sātyaki, Abhimanyu and Citrasena must be pondered over before proclaiming his glory. This chapter will further throw light on certain overlooked and misstated actions of Kaṛṇa in Mahābhārata.

The Birth of Kaṛṇa

According to Mahābhārata, King Śūrasena of Yādava dynasty, had a beautiful young daughter named Pṛta (later called Kuntī). Once, Ṛṣi Durvāsā visited the king for a prolonged stay at his palace as a guest. Śūrasena asked Pṛta to ensure that Durvāsā's stay was comfortable. Delighted with his stay and her assiduous services, Durvāsā thanked her and gave her a mantra, which would allow her to invoke any deity to provide her with a child. Being young and curious, Pṛta tried to check whether the mantra would actually work. As the sun rose the next day, she initiated the mantra and invoked the Sūrya Deva. He came bejewelled with a golden glow, adorning a breastplate, and blessed her with her first son. Pṛta was confused, remorseful, and worried about having a baby out of wedlock. She put the newborn baby in a basket and set it afloat in the river Aśvanadī near the palace. The basket reached the river Carmaṇvatī, and subsequently the Ganges River and finally reached the kingdom of Aṅga (ancient Bengal). There, it was found by Rādha, a charioteer's wife. She took the baby to her husband, Adhīratā Nandana. They named him Vasuṣeṇa and decided to raise him as their own child. Later, he received names like Kaṛṇa, Rādheya and Vaikarta too.



There are several stories behind the name 'Karna'. During the Pāṇḍavas' twelfth year of exile, Lord Indra came to Karna (formerly known as Vasuṣeṇa) to ask for his Kavaca-Kuṇḍala (Armour and earrings that were part of his body right from birth). He got the name Vaikarta and Karna as he cut off the Kavaca from his body and the Kuṇḍala from his ears. The

origin of the words Karṇa and Vaikarta comes from Karṇa (करण) and kṛtī (कृती) respectively, which means cutting off.

Karṇa: A Life Invested in Vexation

Karṇa's life has been a perpetual attempt to outshine and defeat Arjuna. He was blinded by jealousy and an inferiority complex towards Arjuna's prowess. He spent his student days acquiring auspicious weapons and rare skills to become invincible and superior to Arjuna. Karṇa sought the help of Paraśurāma - the guru of Droṇacārya - to excel Arjuna in archery. The story of Droṇa refusing Karṇa as a student is gravely misconstrued. He only refused to give Karṇa the Brahmāstra since it was already given to Arjuna and Aśvatthāmā. Karṇa needed a superior weapon to excel over Arjuna. He approached Paraśurāma disguised as a Brahmana because Paraśurāma had taken a vow not to teach archery to Kṣatriyas. He succeeded in deceiving Paraśurāma initially, but Paraśurāma eventually found out the truth and he cursed Karṇa, because of which he couldn't use the knowledge he gained to save himself in war.

Droṇa held a tournament in Hāstinapura after his students graduated, where his disciples exhibited their dexterity and mastery of various skills. Just as Arjuna displayed his preeminent archery skills, Karṇa stepped forward and surpassed all of Arjuna's accomplishments. Being an uninvited participant in the ceremony, it is evident that his sole intention was to transcend Arjuna's reputation. He also wanted to stir a battle with Arjuna which was inappropriate

on that occasion. This tendency stayed with him throughout his life. The only person impressed by this was Duryodhana, who subsequently crowned Karṇa as the King of Aṅga, sealing a strong alliance against Pāṇḍavas.

Karṇa and Duryodhana: A bond that unleashed viciousness in each other

Karṇa's friendship with Duryodhana is a much-discussed alliance in Mahābhārata. Karṇa was indebted to Duryodhana for elevating him from a charioteer's son to the King of Aṅga. But their friendship wasn't based purely on commitment and brotherhood. It was a means for both of them to attain their individual goals. In a conversation with Śrī Kṛṣṇa, Karṇa reveals that it is not his moral obligation to Duryodhana but rather his own will to destroy Arjuna and maintain his power, that made him stay with the Kauravas. Karṇa says,

"In consequence also of my connection with Duryodhana of Dhṛtarāṣṭra's race, I have, O Kṛṣṇa, enjoyed sovereignty for thirteen years, without a thorn in my side. Obtaining me, O Kṛṣṇa, Duryodhana hath, O thou of Vrishni's race, made this preparation for an armed encounter and provoked hostilities with the sons of Pāṇḍu. And it is for this, O Acyuta, that in the battle (that will ensue), I, O Kṛṣṇa, have been chosen as the great antagonist of Arjuna to advance against him in single combat." [K M Ganguly's translation]

Karṇa associated with Duryodhana's evil schemes against Pāṇḍavas not out of compulsion but out of his resentment towards Arjuna. He prepared the roadmap for every criminal

act done against the Pāṇḍavas including their attempt to murder them in Vana Parva. He was also responsible for the unfortunate course of events in the Game of Dice. It was Karṇa who instructed Duḥśāsan to disrobe Draupadī. In the Kurukṣetra war, when he realised that it was not possible to defeat Abhimanyu one-on-one, it was Karṇa's idea to attack and kill Abhīmanyu together inside the Cakravyūha. Śrī Kṛṣṇa again accounts all this in Karṇa's final battle with Arjuna.

Amidst this, there is more that directly questions Karṇa's friendship with Duryodhana. Even though they joined hands to oppose the Pāṇḍavas, Karṇa betrayed and ditched Duryodhana during several crucial situations. For instance, when Karṇa and Kauravas were attacked by Gāndharva Citrasenā, Karṇa fled from the battlefield leaving Duryodhana high and dry. This incident shows not only his lack of ethical and moral principles as a warrior, but also his lack of faithfulness in his friendship with Duryodhana. Finally, it was Yudhiṣṭhira who came to Duryodhana's rescue.

Similarly, in Virāṭa Parva, Karṇa suspects that the Pāṇḍavas were living in disguise with King Virāṭa during their ordained 'Ajñātavasam' (living incognito). They stole herds of cows belonging to Virāṭa's kingdom in an attempt to lure the king to war. They expected Arjuna to come out and fight them on behalf of King Virāṭa. Karṇa vowed to Duryodhana over his sword that he would kill Arjuna in the war. But Arjuna who was in the guise of the transgender Bṛhannala, squarely defeated Karṇa and Duryodhana. Unable to tolerate the

humiliation, Duryodhana decided to end his life by sitting over a spread of dārbha grass while Karna deserted the battle, again. While Duryodhana was confident that he could defeat Bhīma himself, he needed a good archer to counter Arjuna. That is where Karna came in handy for him. Karna also participated in many scheming acts against Pāṇḍavas out of his own will. Hence, the friendship between Karna and Duryodhana was purely for mutual benefit. The praise for Karna's commitment to his friendship is unsubstantial.

Karna's Death: Dharma or Adharma?

Another misstated account exalting Karna as a tragic hero is that of Arjuna killing him when he was unarmed. Karna's death was the result of his own evil karma. When Śrī Kṛṣṇa saw Dharma failing in his actions, he approached Karna and said;

"You are the eldest son of Queen Kuntī. You are supposed to fight on the side of Dharma. Don't stick with the side for the sake of benefits you get. It is Dharma that should become victorious. Only then people will be victorious. You should not befriend adharma just for the sake of selfish desires. Protecting the world is a greater goal. Please come. Please come."

Karna refused to go with him; hence Kṛṣṇa felt no remorse when Karna was killed. He gave him a chance to change his fate and the rest was up to him. Adding to all of these, Karna's character becomes transparent in the small things he did as well. Once, he killed a Brahmin's calf for eating up flowers from his garden. The brahmin cursed him, "The wheels of

your chariot would be dragged in the soil during the time of the war". During the Kurukṣetra war, Karṇa took all the opportunities to destroy Arjuna. But in that fateful battle with Arjuna, the wheel of his chariot got stuck in the soil as the Brahmin had cursed.

Karṇa ends up in front of Arjuna, without weapons, trying to pull out his chariot from the sand. And Karṇa requests Arjuna for Dharma. The same Karṇa who sat high and mighty, much before, denying Dharma to Arjuna's wife Draupadī. The same Karṇa who sat in his chariot denying Dharma to Abhimanyu in the ground. For all he did, he ended up just like Draupadī and Abhimanyu, in the low ground, asking for Dharma, that too to his arch rival Arjuna.

He asked him, "O Arjuna, you are a pious man. Please allow me time to pull out the wheels of my chariot". But it was Śrī Kṛṣṇa who responded. His response was a reminder to Karṇa that he cannot seek the protection of Dharma as Karṇa had violated and denied dharma throughout his life. This reminder to Karṇa, also reminded Arjuna of all the adharmas that Karṇa had done in the past. Arjuna then continued to battle Karna, and finally killed him in the battlefield.

Amma says, "Dharma is the root principle of Life. Our conscience should always be like a well-balanced needle on the measuring scale". Even though Karṇa acquired superior knowledge and skills, he failed to keep this balance and hence perished.

Conclusion

There are various opinions on the merits of Karna's character. Lack of rational thinking led him to adharma. His unwillingness to forgive or compromise resulted in his own demise. Karna's attitude towards elders, including profound teachers like Droṇa, Bhīṣma and Śalya, shows that despite one's might, all endeavours become fruitful only with the blessings of our elders and the grace of God. Karna was disillusioned throughout his life, being dragged into a maze of betrayal by his mother, teacher and society. He failed to use the knowledge he had acquired with great effort at the right moment. He couldn't contain and control his envy and hatred towards Arjuna. He desired to prove himself better than Arjuna on the battlefield but had to pay for it with his own life. He worked very hard only to surpass someone else and not to improve himself for the sake of his own happiness. Karna embodies the amalgamation of right and wrong, good and bad in human nature. Nevertheless, as Hiltebeitel points out "[...] Karna inspires admiration, affection, and a wish for things to have gone otherwise, as is ultimately expressed by Kuntī and Yudhiṣṭhira." In spite of his flaws, Karna's inherent goodness makes him an appealing character who captures the audience's attention even today (quoted in Kohler, 2014, p.35)

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Chapter 9

**KINGSHIP AND POLITY
ACUMEN**

Take charge of your life, your family, your company, or your nation! Mahābhārata holds gems of wisdom to shape you into a true leader.

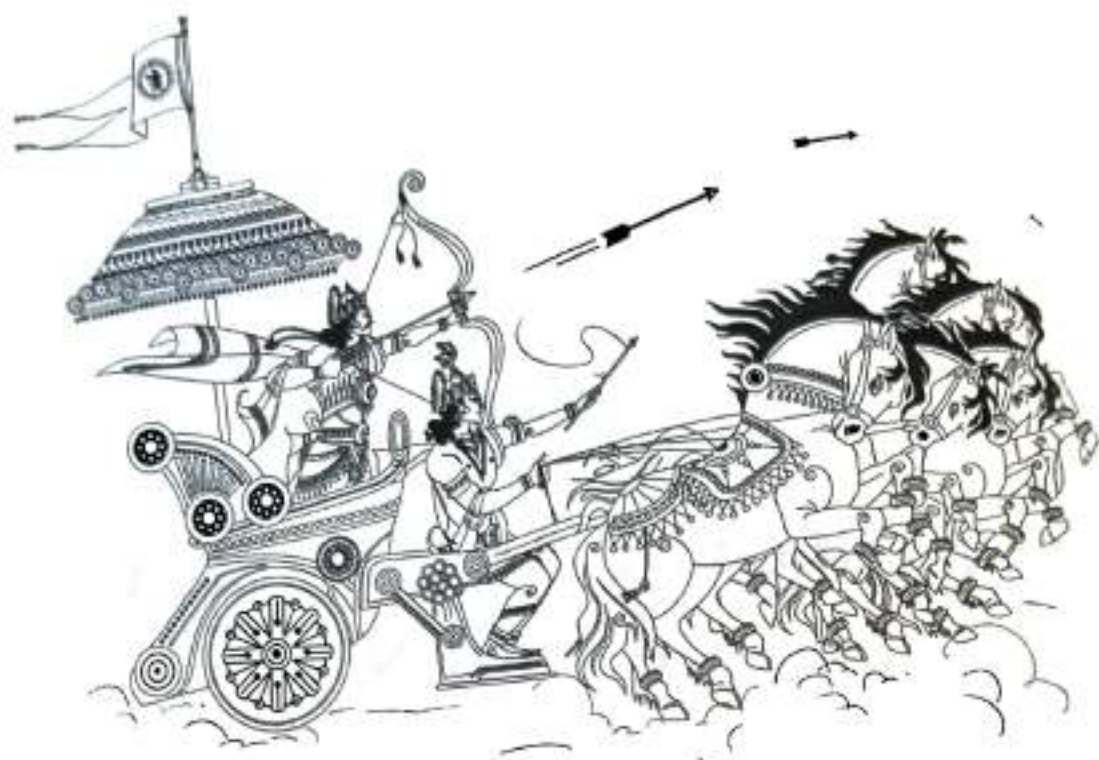


Chapter 9

KINGSHIP AND POLITY ACUMEN

Every country has its own system of law and order. The way it works differs significantly from country to country. On the 6th of January 2021, a group of protesters marched towards the Capitol in the US, leading to a riot that killed five and injured hundreds [1]. On 26th January 2021, mobs hijacked the Republic Day Tractor Parade in India, stormed into the Red Fort and hoisted their flag [2]. Both these incidents show us an attitude of Adharma, disregard for the law and failure of state policies. What can governments do when they come across such crises? Will it help if they redefine policies of governance, maybe a proper reconstruction of ideas and rules related to state administration?

Are you wondering what all this has to do with Mahābhārata? Anything related to the four Puruṣārthas, Dharma, Artha, Kāma and Mokṣa can be found in Mahābhārata. This grand Itihāsa offers solutions to all such concerns.



धर्मे चार्थे च कामे च मोक्षे च भरतर्षभ
यदिहास्ति तदन्यत्र यन्नेहास्ति न तत्कचित्

*dharme cārthe ca kāme ca mokṣe ca bharatarṣabha
yadihāsti tadanyatra yannehāsti na tatkvacit*

“Whatever is found in Mahābhārata about Dharma, Artha, Kāma and Mokṣa, maybe found anywhere else.

But, of these whatever is not in this Itihāsa, cannot be found elsewhere.”

Mahābhārata 01.56.33

Let us look for laws and policies from Mahābhārata, worth emulating today. The module explores why ideas on governance suggested by Mahābhārata need to be taken up

today. Finally, we examine the practicality of these ideas for nation and nation-building.

The Analogy of the Ideal Republic

If one needs the details of what a just state is like, then better try to understand Bhīṣma's ideas. He explains how a state might embody great virtues like wisdom and justice. Bhīṣma embarks on a long exposition about the ideal republic. He sets forth this idea,

नैव राज्यं न राजासीन्न दण्डो न च दाण्डिकः
धर्मेणैव प्रजाः सर्वा रक्षन्ति च परस्परम्

*naiva rājyaṃ na rājāsīnna daṇḍo na ca dāṇḍikah
dharmenaiva prajāḥ sarvā rakṣanti ca parasparam*

Mahābhārata 12.59.14

This is part of a conversation between Bhīṣma and Yudhiṣṭhira from Śānti Parva. It means, "There is no kingdom nor any king, no lawbreaker nor any magistrate to administer a penalty to the wrongdoer. People protect each other by virtue of Dharma." What a venerable thought! Here Bhīṣma stresses one thing - holding on to Dharma. Within Mahābhārata Dharma is defined as,

धारणाद्धर्म इत्याहुर्धर्मेण विधृताः प्रजाः

dhāraṇāddharma ityāhurdharmeṇa vidhṛtāḥ prajāḥ

Mahābhārata 12.110.11

The word 'Dharma' is derived from the root word 'dhṛ-dhāraṇe', which means to uphold. When people do the right thing and hold on to righteousness, a stable society is

formed. In this manner, anything that holds people together, as they are, is defined as Dharma. If all the inhabitants of a country adhere to Dharma, then we have a healthy and progressive society there. The validity of this notion by Bhīṣma is eminent even today. There is a pressing need to impart such noble thoughts to ensure that a country, or the world at large, can move forward and become a prosperous and truly progressive society.

The conversation continued and Yudhiṣṭhira asked, "O King! How can a kingdom be protected? How can a kingdom be won over?" Bhīṣma replied, "One must appoint a headman for every village, then one for ten villages, one for twenty, one for one hundred, and one for one thousand. The headman protects the village, ascertains any problems the village faces, and reports everything about the villagers to the supervisor of ten, who reports to the supervisor of twenty" [3]. A faithful supervisor will implement all the instructions given by the head of state.

Bhīṣma then emphasizes the need to appoint spies. "He must appoint spies to travel throughout the Earth. Let them find out if my policy is sound and whether my conduct is praised. Do they like me in the countryside and what is my reputation in the kingdom?" [3]. This is still relevant today. Every country needs trustworthy spies who report to the head directly, as detailed precisely in Mahābhārata.

In the Sabhā Parva, the conversation between Mahārṣi Nārada and Yudhiṣṭhira also reveals a lot. Mahārṣi asks, "Do you use groups of three spies, who do not know one another,

to find out about the eighteen tirthās on the other side and the fifteen on your own territory?" The tirthās mentioned here means ministries - a bureau headed by a minister. The hint here is to deploy three mutually unknown spies and collect details from eighteen categories of people on the other side and fifteen categories of people on their own side. The eighteen categories of people to be monitored on the opposite side include the Minister, Chief Priests, Head of Judiciary, Head of Treasury, Head of the City, etc." [4].

Mahābhārata's Economic Thought

Does Mahābhārata offer insights into how well an economy can be managed? An emphatic Yes! In the conversation between Bhīṣma and Yudhiṣṭhira in Śānti Parva, Bhīṣma instructs in detail regarding the economy and collection of taxes. "Every town will have one Supervisor. He must check the sales, purchases, expenses, shops, and routes of traders, impose taxes, and act to ensure their 'yoga and kṣema' (prosperity). He must glance towards the production and expenses of artisans, to ensure that they have a good living and the craft flourishes. The taxes must be commensurate."

This instruction in Mahābhārata proposes the need to connect the history of Indian economic thought with Itihāsas. Among all the myriad characters in the Itihāsa, it was Bhīṣma and Nārada who imparted the wisdom of kingship and polity in Yudhiṣṭhira. There is much more in Mahābhārata, about economic well-being, that is presented in a dialogue.

In the Sabhā Parva, Maharṣi Nārada checks how well Yudhiṣṭhira was spending his wealth. Maharṣi asked, "Is your wealth spent properly?". He also asked, "Do you pay wages to your soldiers in advance? O' scorcher of enemies! Do you distribute riches from the enemy kingdom among the chiefs of your army, in accordance with what they deserve?"

Maharṣi Nārada posed some more questions to the King. "Do you examine a work and praise the creator? Do you honour good ones among good people?" Here Maharṣi wishes that the King award people with gifts of wealth according to their efforts. By now, we should feel proud while quoting about economic well-being from Mahābhārata, rather than from Milton Friedman or Simon Kuznets.

The Nature of Jurisdiction

In the Śānti Parva, as the conversation between Bhīṣma and Yudhiṣṭhira continues, insights into justice and the welfare of subjects are revealed at great length. He said, "A King who desires Dharma should rule so that he is engaged in the welfare of his subjects and considers the time, the place, and the strength. Since he thinks of welfare for them and his own self, the King should ensure that Dharma prevails in the kingdom in every way. He must milk the kingdom like a bee sucks honey without damaging the flower and flies away. He must milk the cow bearing the calf in mind, without causing damage to the udders."

Bhīṣma even gives practical advice that it is extremely difficult for a King to behave similarly towards all men. He warns Yudhiṣṭhira that, "Drinking houses, prostitutes,

pimps, gamblers and others who are like them must all be controlled. They can cause injury to the kingdom.” This warning is very much relevant even today, where we see mob violence and vandalism around the globe, initiated by paid or misled individuals, and those who live off agitations.

In a famous yet undelivered speech, Macaulay says he has not seen beggars in India [5]. Macaulay may not have said this. But the mighty Bhīṣma insisted that Yudhiṣṭhira not allow anyone to beg for a living in his kingdom. He says, “Unless there is a disaster, no one should ever beg. However, if there is a disaster, one can beg from others. Compassionate people who wish to show pity can then follow Dharma and give. But in general, there should not be any beggars in the kingdom.”

This elaborate and extensive dialogue between Bhīṣma and Yudhiṣṭhira helps us understand much about how well a country can be governed. India has a long history of kings and political leaders taking cues on governance from great sages and ṛṣis. From Cāṇakya to Śrī Rāmakṛṣṇa Paramahansa, from Samarth Rāmdās to Thāthāchariar, from Vidyāraṇya Swāmi to Mātā Amritānandamayī Devī all of them have given valuable advice to different rulers. For instance, after meeting Mātā Amritānandamayī Devī, Amma, former Indian president Dr. A P J Abdul Kalām said, “The message I get from Amma is to Give. Go on giving. You can give. It is not only money. You can share knowledge. You can remove the pain. And you can even go to the person who is suffering.”[6]

Misplaced Compassion

An important aspect of Mahābhārata still relevant for national security is 'misplaced compassion'. In the name of compassion and high moral standards, the government has given pardons and relaxation on several occasions where it required strict actions instead. Lord Kṛṣṇa revealed this attitude towards adharmic / asura forces during Karṇa's final battle with Arjuna.

Karṇa's chariot gets stuck in the sand. He tries to pull it out whilst battling with Arjuna but in vain. Finally, he decides to seek time to pull out the chariot wheel. He hails Arjuna, a man of Dharma, to cease his Adharma of fighting a soldier on the ground from a chariot. As Arjuna begins to lower his weapon, Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa intervenes, "Oh Rādheya! Now you remember Dharma!" Bhagavān then reminded Karṇa of his adharmic deeds, especially with Draupadī and Abhimanyu. This served as a reminder to Arjuna too. He raised his Gāṇḍiva yet again and continued fighting with Karṇa.

Śrī Kṛṣṇa also intervened during the Gadāyuddha between Bhīma and Duryodhana, and via Arjuna, signals to Bhīma to kill Duryodhana by hitting him in the thighs. Bhīma follows the same and instantly, the warrior Duryodhana is brought down. This seemingly adharmic act makes Balarāma and others furious and they pick an argument with Bhīma and Yudhiṣṭhira. However, Bhagavān explains his part here in detail. For him, Duryodhana was the embodiment of

adharma and there is no reason not to use adharma to kill him. Not only this, Śrī Kṛṣṇa extends this theory to previous attacks on Bhīṣma, Droṇa, and Bhūriśravas and defends the Pāṇḍavas for killing them. One important point to note here is that Kṛṣṇa is not advocating adharmic methods in all battles, but uses them as a last resort to kill enemies who have resorted to adharmic methods. This tactic was lost to our civilisational memory and the examples of Prithvirāj Chauhān's encounter with Muhammed Ghorī and more recently, the 1962 episode with China are grave reminders of this fact. This policy towards adharmic/asuric forces practised by Kṛṣṇa has a lesson for Indian national security policymakers. Until recently, specifically until the Bālākoṭ strikes and Gālvān incident, the border management of India always suffered from 'misplaced compassion'. To suppress the increasing number of internal and external enemies, India has to practice this policy of Kṛṣṇa with much more vigour.

Finally, Mahābhārata has a piece of advice to the head of the state, the modern equivalent to a king or monarch. Hidden in one of the lesser-known episodes of Mahābhārata, the Janaka - Brāhmaṇa Saṁvāda of Anugīta Parva of Aśvamedhika Parva, Kṛṣṇa narrates the story of King Janaka to Arjuna. Let us listen to the conversation between King Janaka and the Brāhmaṇa. As a punishment for the crime committed by a Brāhmaṇa, King Janaka asked him to leave his country and live elsewhere. Now the Brāhmaṇa has a question, "Which kingdom is under your subjugation? If I know this, I can live

in another king's country." This makes the king thoughtful and after contemplating for a while, the king permits the Brāhmaṇa to stay wherever he wishes. On contemplating, the King understood that the nation did not belong to him, nor to his forefathers. He said that he has conquered the five senses, and mind and renounced Mamatā (attachment). Having controlled the mind, the king performed actions only for the benefit of others. At this point in the story, the Brāhmaṇa reveals that he is Dharmarāja who has come in disguise to test the king. Dharmarāja says,

त्वमस्य ब्रह्मलाभस्य दुर्वारस्यानिवर्तिनः ।
सत्त्वेनेमिनिरुद्धस्य चक्रस्यैकः प्रवर्तकः ॥

*tvamasya brahmalābhasya durvārasyānivartinah |
sattvaneminiruddhasya cakrasyaikah pravartakah ||*

Mahābhārata 14.32.25

"Only such a king, who renounced his Mamatā and works for the benefit of others, is suitable for controlling the dharma cakra in the universe, whose spokes are of Sattva Guṇas and whose purpose is Brahma Prāpti." Here, Dharmarāja narrates that a king, by virtue of his governance, may attain Brahma Pada. What a glorious thought this is. Governance as a medium of salvation. This attitude of kings, if practised by our national leaders, will surely make India, a Viśvaguru again in all domains.

To conclude, the earlier instance explains that we Indians should take advantage of the insights and lessons from Mahābhārata for individual and national progress. For that,

they must have exposure to the practical aspects of their lessons. It is said in Mahābhārata that,

कालो वा कारणं राज्ञो राजा वा कालकारणम्
इति ते संशयो मा भूद्राजा कालस्य कारणम्

*kālo vā kāraṇam rājño rājā vā kālakāraṇam
iti te saṁśayo mā bhūdrājā kālasya kāraṇam*

Mahābhārata 12.70.06

Here, Bhīṣma advises Yudhiṣṭhira that “You should not entertain any doubt about whether Time is instrumental in the creation of a king or the king responsible for the present day (Time). The king causes the present situation (Time).” [translation by Bibek Debroy, Mahābhārata].

Yes, Kings create the destiny of the nation. And in a democracy, we, the people, create kings and are solely responsible for the creation of a new India. Just like a firm, ruling a nation also demands certain strategic approaches to various cultures.

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Chapter 10

MAHĀBHĀRATA IN ADAGES

“Even if you don’t know the first thing about the Mahābhārata, chances are you’ve still used a phrase or two that came straight from its storyline. Breaking cultural and linguistic boundaries, this poetic work has seeped into the collective psyche of an entire civilization. The ripples of the itihasa have spread out even into the most mundane aspects of our lives.”



Chapter 10

MAHĀBHĀRATA IN ADAGES

Adages are part and parcel of any conversation, be it casual, formal, or literary. People always want to communicate effectively and express themselves in different ways. The efficacy of any communication primarily depends on the knowledge and expertise of the individual. At the same time, an expert can also improve this effectiveness by using hand gestures, facial expressions, and modulation of voice.

Further, command over language can also ensure effective communication. Here, vocabulary and grammatical knowledge are obvious aspects. In addition, the use of adages popular in that particular language also plays an important role in boosting the efficacy of communication.

Adages can be found in all languages, and grace their heritage. They are more often considered and discussed as part of various dialects in linguistic studies. Most times, the

source of such adages remains unknown to the speaker. They may have been born from the historical experiences of that community and passed down from generation to generation. Or they may have been adopted from conversational pieces of those who influenced the community at large or may have been borrowed from literary compositions that influenced or inspired the community. While some adages are sūktas with superior philosophical ideas, some are simply 'proverbial sayings' used in casual conversations. Thus, adages can ascribe various depths of meaning to a conversation.

In this chapter, we will discuss some adages associated with Mahābhārata. We will also briefly deal with the context of these adages within Mahābhārata. From the other chapter of this book, we would have learned and appreciated how Mahābhārata has been continually influencing our society for over thousands of years.

All Indians must have had direct insights into how their social life and intellectual life are influenced by this grand itihāsa. For instance, a child may get excited seeing a giant man and tell his mother, "Ma, today I saw someone as big as Bhīma". Even a child instinctively remembers Bhīma when he encounters a giant man. Also, one can see that such a comparison is done by referring to Bhīma and not with the giant Kumbhakarna from Rāmāyaṇa who is much bigger in size. Then again, one uses Kumbhakarna to compare someone who is fond of sleeping. Thus, many elements of Mahābhārata have become common expressions of language in our daily life. It is also worth mentioning here

that the word Mahābhārata itself has become a meaningful expression. When a terrible fight takes place, even if verbal, most Indians present it as if a Mahābhārata war has passed.



Let us look some typical examples of Mahābhārata in adages.

यतो धर्मस्ततो जयः

Yato Dharmastato Jayaha

Where there is Dharma, there is Victory

If Mahābhārata were a song, then 'Yato dharmastato jayaha' would be the refrain.

This short verse is the primary message of Mahābhārata. The word 'Jaya' here means victory. Keep in mind that the first form of Mahābhārata was named 'Jaya'. Hence the central message of Jaya or Mahābhārata is 'Victory to Dharma'. This core thematic adage of Mahābhārata has appeared at many places in the itihāsa as part of many conversations. Let me point out an important one.

When the battle between the Dhārtharāṣṭras (Sons of Dhṛtarāṣṭra) and the Pāṇḍavas (Sons of Pāṇḍu) was announced, Duryodhana went to seek blessings from his mother Gāndhārī. As he prostrated before her, she blessed him saying, "Yato Dharmastato Jayaha". Perhaps it was another attempt by that poor mother to invoke the glorious thought of dharma in her son. This simple verse is the most precise representation of the philosophy of dharma. The same verse appears in four different situations, associated with Gāndhārī, though it was Karṇa who first used it. This verse is also recited by Bhīṣma, Vyāsa, Arjuna, and Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa.

Today this message is inscribed on the emblem of the Supreme Court of India, our highest judicial body. This in itself is an indicator of how much it has influenced the children of India. The popular writer Śrī Narendra Kohli, who touched the heart of India through his writings on Itihāsas, Bhāgavatam, Life of Swāmi Vivekānanda, etc. titled his analysis of Mahābhārata as 'Yato Dharmastato Jayaha'.

It is no wonder everyone in India from the Himālayas in the North to Kanyākumari in the South knows this adage. We can see millions of people who can quote this phrase as it is, in their life instances. For centuries, this adage has been used plentifully from laymen to intellectuals alike. There are also people who use this in their own colloquial way rather than quoting it as it is. This is the most popular adage given by Mahābhārata, 'Yato Dharmastato Jayaha'.

अति सर्वत्र वर्जयेत्

Ati sarvatra varjayet

Excess of Anything has to be Forsaken

This is another popular adage associated with Mahābhārata. This is not a verse from the textual Mahābhārata rather it is part of a famous Subhāṣita ('well-spoken verses'). The complete Subhāṣita is,

अतिदानाद्धतः कर्णस्त्व अतिलोभात् सुयोधनः ।

अतिकामाद्दशग्रीवस्त्व अति सर्वत्र वर्जयेत् ॥

atidānāddhataḥ kaṛṇastv atilobhāt suyodhanaḥ |

atikāmāddaśagrīvastv ati sarvatra varjayet ||

There are textual variations of this verse. But in all those variations, Duryodhana appears in the second quarter. He is presented as a symbol of greed. He is also pictured as an example of inflated pride, in some. Two mighty mainstream characters of Mahābhārata appear here to substantiate its message.

There are two phrases – *ati dānat* (excessive donation/charity) conveyed through Karṇa and *ati lobhāt* (excessive greed) associated with Duryodhana. Karṇa donated his natural protective shield which paved the way for his death. This is presented here as an example of mindless donation. Indeed, generosity is a good quality. But we must understand that it should not be self-destructive. We see people who are very generous without comprehending the subtleties of Dharma. History has witnessed many such great emperors of India who were subdued by their enemies because of their misplaced compassion and generosity.

Similarly, excessive greed results in terrible harm. If Duryodhana had settled for half the kingdom, he could have lived his whole life contentedly. This would have even avoided the dreadful bloodshed that resulted from the war. But he paved the way, not only to his own destruction but also of tens of thousands into the tears of war.

The last part of the verse '*ati sarvatra varjayet*' tells us that, just like excess charity or excess greed, an excess of anything can lead us to our destruction. And hence we need to exercise control and give up this quest for excess.

महाजनो येन गतः स पन्थाः

mahājano yena gataḥ sa panthāḥ
The Way of Mahatmas is the Way

This is another important adage used popularly in debates on dharma. This is part of a śloka from Mahābhārata. The complete śloka is as follows.

तर्कोऽप्रतिष्ठः श्रुतयो विभिन्ना नासाव ऋषिर्यस्य मतं न भिन्नम्।
 धर्मस्य तत्त्वं निहितं गुहायां महाजनो येन गतः स पन्थाः॥

tarko 'pratiṣṭhaḥ śrutayo vibhinnā nāsāv ṛṣir yasya matam
na bhinnam |
dharmasya tattvaṁ nihitaṁ guhāyām mahājano yena
gataḥ sa panthāḥ ||

Through mere logical arguments and contemplation, one cannot determine the subtle principle of dharma. If one decides to follow dharma by relying on intellectual arguments, then it means one will have to accept and follow the words of the person who is more intelligent. Similarly, it is very difficult to distinguish the subtle tenets of dharma directly from vedic scriptures since they are diverse and highly contextual. If one decides to follow only one ācārya (teacher), then only a few theories of that ācārya will be universally acceptable. It is often said that the principle of dharma is like a treasure hidden in a cave. The only way is to follow the path taken by Mahātmas.

The Upa-parva 'Yakṣa praśna' in the Vana Parva presents many discussions related to dharma. The incident happens during the exile of the Pāṇḍavas in the Dvaita forest.

Yudhiṣṭhira saw his dear brothers who went to fetch drinking water, lying dead on the banks of a lake. Since he was also extremely thirsty, he decided to drink water from the lake. Suddenly he heard a voice from the skies that forbade him from drinking the water, "I am a crane who owns this lake. Your brothers died because they didn't answer my questions. If you try drinking the water without answering my questions, the same will be your fate". Later the crane reveals that he is a Yakṣa (nature-spirit). Yudhiṣṭhira then answered all the questions of the Yakṣa.

One of the questions was, "kāḥ panthāḥ", which means, 'What is the way?' Yudhiṣṭhira answers with the above-mentioned adage. Since Yudhiṣṭhira gave the correct answers to all the questions that followed, Yakṣa restored the life of his brothers and freed them. Yakṣa finally revealed that he was Dharma Deva.

This adage is one of the most widely followed and accepted in Sanātana Dharma. The acceptance of this adage is revealed by the fact that at different times in different societies many great rishis have been recognized as ideal to follow.

वयं पंचाधिकम शतम्

Vayam panchādhikam shatam

We Should Stand United

This adage indicates that the path to the well-being of a society is to stand together, to achieve together, and experience together. Other phrases such as Unity is strength, 'saṃhatih kāryasādhikā' (things, when put together, can

do great work), etc. are also popular in the same essence. It primarily means there will be prosperity only when we move forward with one mind. This is essential for the progress of a race.

Mahābhārata draws the great war on a big canvas not only to portray the ultimate triumph of dharma, but also to show the tragic downfall of the disunited. Yudhishtira who was a part of this great war believed their dynasty should always remain in unity. He tried many times to make this happen but failed miserably due to the stubbornness of the opposite side.

During the exile of the Pāṇḍavas, Duryodhana was captured by Gandharvas in the forest. Knowing this, Yudhishtira asks Bhīma and Arjuna to defeat the Gandharvas and release Duryodhana from captivity. Then they asked their elder brother, “Won’t it be easy for us if Duryodhana gets killed by the Gandharvas?” And the wise Yudhishtira responded thus,

परैः पिरभवे प्राप्ते वयं पञ्चोत्तरं शतम् ।
परस्परिवरोधे तु वयं पञ्चैव ते शतम् ॥

*Parai: paribhave prāpte vayaṁ pañcottaram śatam |
parasparavirodhe tu vayaṁ pañcaiva te śatam ||*

It means, ‘When an external force takes over the Kuruvamśa, we, the Dhārtharāṣṭras and the Pāṇḍavas together are 105 people in strength. Though when we Pāṇḍavas and Dhārtharāṣṭras fight each other for the kingdom, we stand separately. This verse also comes in Vana Parva.

We should unhesitatingly apply this phrase in our national, social, and family lives. Then through us, the establishments that are our nation, community and family will prosper sustainably.

Popular Maxims

When we discuss such phrases of Mahābhārata, Nyāyas also deserves to be mentioned. Nyāyas have been translated by the famous scholar Colonel G A Jacob as 'Popular Maxims' (Handful of Popular Maxims, volume 1-3). In the third volume of his book, he said, "Now a word regarding the title of these pamphlets. I am by no means satisfied with 'Maxim' as the equivalent of Nyāya, but adopted it because many scholars had already done so. It would therefore be better in my opinion to adopt the term Nyāya itself without translating it into English".

Nyāyas are popular like idioms when we use different vernaculars in Indian languages. When certain stories from our ancient history, myths, and legends get deeply engraved in the minds of the people, the community imbibes certain principles emerging from these stories. These principles can be presented in a word or phrase to represent great logic. Such short phrases are known as Nyāyas. These could be found in similar forms in other languages, also. For example, the Nyāya, 'Asidhāra' is famous in Sanskrit. There is a similar English expression, 'Razor's edge'. With this brief introduction to Nyāyas, let us examine some of the Nyāyas from Mahābhārata.

kūrmāṅga Nyāya

Jacob translates it as “The maxim of limbs of a tortoise”. *kūrma* means Tortoise and *Anga* means organs. The Gīta says that a devotee should withdraw his senses from the sense objects, just as a tortoise withdraws its limbs into its shell (Bhagavadgīta 2.58). This Nyāya represents many such things that can be withdrawn and re-manifested. Mādhavācārya uses this logical reasoning in *Samkhya Prakarana* in *Sarvadarshana Sangraha* to indicate the effect arising from a cause (Sāmkhya Darśan 18). It is also used by Vācaspati Miśra in *Samkhyatattvā Kaumudī* (Chapter 9).

Sundopasunda Nyāya

This is used to describe mutual destruction. Jacob quotes that ‘Laukika - Nyāya - Saṅgraha’ by Raghunathavarma explains the story behind it.

“Anyonya Nāshya nāshaka bhāva vivakshāyām Sundopasunda Nyāya. Yatha hi Sundopasundasanjaya Sahodaravasura Thilothamārtham Vadhyaghatakabhavena Ubhau Api Nashtana Iti Bhārathe Prasidham”, A handful of proverbs (Page 85). The foundation story of this Nyāya appears in chapters 209 to 212 of the Mahābhārata Ādi Parva. The asuras Sunda and Upasunda were invincible brothers. They conquered the three worlds. Brahma asked Viśvakarma to find a way to destroy them. Viśvakarma created the beautiful apsara Thilothamā. Brahmā sent her to the Sundopasundas and the two fought and died trying to own the charming lady. In the 13th commentary on

Samkhyatattvā Kaumudī, Vācaspati Miśra refers to this argument in Śloka 61, Section 9.

Conclusion

Thus, Mahābhārata is widely used in our sayings and Nyāyas. There are many expressions in languages all over India, such as 'Urvaśī śāpam Upakāram' which indicates 'a curse that turned out to be a timely boon'. 'Vyāsa Ghatta', which means difficult to comprehend. 'Dātha Karṇasama or Dāne Karṇasama', which means 'very generous donation'. All this shows how much Mahābhārata has seeped into the minds of Indian people. We hope this literature will inspire you to delve deeper into the ocean of Mahābhārata and acquire the philosophical gems there.



Chapter 11

POPULAR REGIONAL TALES

There are so many stories based on Mahābhārata, that we find in the public spaces. And why Not? Being a rich and complex work, it has inspired countless retellings, reimaginings, and interpretations over the centuries. While some remain true to the essence and substance of Vyasa's original composition, others have dared creative liberties to offer their own unique perspective.



Chapter 11

POPULAR REGIONAL TALES

Like a giant tree spreading its fibrous root over vast areas on Earth, Mahābhārata has spread across vast stretches of Greater India, rooted deeply in the culture, tradition, and hearts of the populace. All such regions have their share of this grand Itihāsa, with a unique flavour, lying outside the textual Vyāsa Mahābhārata. We find these narratives in regional writings or in oral traditions and even in art forms and ritual performances. This chapter narrates a few, very popular, regional tales based on Mahābhārata which cannot be found in Vyāsa Mahābhārata.

Story of Arāvan and the Kūvagam Festival

Once Arjuna had to violate the privacy of Yudhiṣṭhira and Draupadī. In a dire situation, he broke the mutual agreement he had with his four brothers. The agreement was that when Draupadī was with one of the Pāṇḍavās, the other four

should not barge in. A Pāṇḍava who breaks this agreement would have to live in the forest for twelve years. Maṇṇi Nārada recommended this kind of agreement to ensure a healthy and sustainable relationship among themselves. As per the agreement Arjuna set out for his twelve-year exile.

During the exile, one day, Arjuna was performing his rituals, bathing in the Gaṅgā, when he met Ulūpī, the Nāga princess. Ulūpī wanted to marry him, and Arjuna agreed [1]. A son was born to them who was named Irāvān / Irāvat / Arāvan [2][3] [4]. He grew up as a splendid Nāga warrior and participated in the battle of Kurukṣetra alongside the Pāṇḍavās. In Vyāsa Mahābhārata, Irāvān dies a heroic death on the battlefield, fighting the rākṣasa Alambuṣa [5].

In the earliest surviving Tamil version of the Mahābhārata, Pārata Venpa, we come across a different account. It was written by the Tamil poet Pēruntevaṇār in the ninth century. Pārata Venpa narrates the story of Arāvan's sacrifice in a ritual called kalappali or 'sacrifice to the battlefield'. It is a ritual performed before battle to ensure victory. To ensure the victory of the Pāṇḍavās, Arāvan sacrifices himself as an offering to Goddess Kālī. However, before the self-sacrifice, Arāvan asks for certain boons from Bhagavān.

Representing his sacrifice to Goddess Kālī, the severed head of Arāvan is the presiding deity at Kūttāṇṭavar Kōvil, a popular temple at Kūvagam Village, Tamil Nādu. The annual festival here attracts lakhs of devotees from across India and abroad as well. The festival relives a boon that Arāvan sought from Bhagavān before he was sacrificed. Arāvan wanted to get

married before his death. Kṛṣṇa grants his wish, transforming himself into the beautiful Mohinī. Arāvan marries Mohinī and is sacrificed the following day. This is re-enacted in this 18-day festival of Arāvan.

Every year in the month of Caitra (April / May), the village of Kūvagam comes to life during this eighteen day festival. Arāvan is worshipped by transgender people of the region, where they are known as 'Arāvanis'. There are three major rituals enacted during the Kūvagam festival. The first is the marriage between Arāvanis and Arāvan, the next is his sacrifice on the following day, and the third involves his widowed partners, the Arāvanis, mourning his death.

The festival consists of various cultural events leading up to its climax on a full moon day. On the fourteenth day of the Kūvagam festival, transgender women dressed as Mohinī gather at the Kūttāṇṭavar Temple. For their marriage to Arāvan, they wear their finest sarees, sparkling bangles, floral garlands, gold jewellery, and bridal makeup. They carry with them various pūjā items, kalaśa or pot, and tāli or maṅgalasūtra. In the sanctum, a group of priests officiates the marriage ceremony and each transgender woman gets married to Arāvan. The priests act as representatives of Arāvan and tie the tāli or sacred thread or knot around their neck and apply siṇdhura / vermillion. On the sixteenth day, the image of Arāvan is taken out in a procession. The newly married transgender women gather at the 'mourning ground' called Azhukalam. When the procession reaches there, the thick floral garlands and accoutrements are removed from

Arāvan's effigy. This symbolises the removal of Arāvan's flesh during his sacrifice on the battlefield. After his death, his widowed partners collectively mourn by removing their maṅgalasūtra and smashing their bangles. They cry aloud and grieve their widowhood. This widowhood is symbolic and temporary. The Arāvanis return every year to repeat the marriage ritual.

The Story of Duṣyanta and Śakuntalā

The story of Duṣyanta and Śakuntalā is dramatised in Kālidāsa's poetic play 'Abhijñānaśākuntalam'. According to this version, King Duṣyanta fell in love with Śakuntalā in one of his hunting expeditions in the forest and married her. Śakuntalā was living in the forest hermitage of Kaṇva Maharṣi. Before going back to his kingdom, Duṣyanta gave Śakuntalā a gold wedding ring with his name on it, promising to return and take Śakuntalā back with him. One day while Śakuntalā was immersed in daydreaming about Duṣyanta, sage Durvāsa happened to visit the ashram. He asked for water but Śakuntalā, lost in thoughts, did not see nor hear him. The sage felt insulted and cursed her that the person whom she was dreaming about, would forget her. As soon as she heard this curse, she begged for forgiveness. Hearing her plea, he said he couldn't take back the curse but could mitigate it. If Duṣyanta is shown something of theirs, he would remember her.

Later a son was born to Śakuntalā. Years passed by and Śakuntalā decided to go and meet Duṣyanta. On the way,



while crossing a river, unfortunately, her golden wedding ring fell into the waters. A fish then swallowed the ring. When Śakuntalā arrived at the palace, the king did not recognize her, probably owing to the curse of Durvāsa. She hence leaves the palace and returns to her hermitage. Her son, Bharata grew up cheerfully among the animals of the forest. Duṣyanta never remembered Śakuntalā, until one day when a fisherman brought him a gold ring as an offering. He told the king that he had found the ring in the stomach of a fish and brought it straight to him. Duṣyanta suddenly remembered Śakuntalā and went desperately in search of her in the forest. He was surprised to see a boy playing with a lion cub. Duṣyanta asked the boy who his parents were. The little boy replied that he was the son of King Duṣyanta and Śakuntalā. Immediately he asked the boy to take him to

his mother. The family was united and Bharata grew up to become a great king.

In the Vyāsa Mahābhārata [7], the core story remains the same. However, when Śakuntalā along with her son appears in Duṣyanta's court, Duṣyanta pretends to forget them in order to avoid embarrassment in front of all and rejects both of them saying that he had no relation with them. In her grief and anger, Śakuntalā retaliates at the unrighteousness and implores them to accept their son at least. With no intention still from Duṣyanta, Śakuntalā decides to leave. But then a disembodied voice spoke to Duṣyanta from the sky. It said that Śakuntalā had indeed spoken the truth, that she was his wife and the boy with her was his son. The voice advised him to support his son and to accept Śakuntalā. Having heard these words, the king of the Puru lineage was delighted. He addressed his priests and advisers telling them that he himself knew very well that this was his son. But if he had accepted him today as his son on Śakuntalā's words alone, there would have been suspicion among all the people and his son would never have been considered his true son. Duṣyanta paid homage and accepted his wife according to the rites of Dharma. Thereupon, King Duṣyanta instated Śakuntalā's son as their heir, and the name of Bharata was conferred on him.

Malanada Duryodhana Temple

Poruvazhi Malanada Temple is the only temple in South India dedicated to Duryodhana [8]. Malanada here means

'temple on the hill'. It is astounding that the Kaurava King who is known for his arrogance and greed is adored as the Saṅkalpa Mūrti or the presiding deity in a temple. Legend is that Duryodhana went searching for the Pāṇḍavās while they were in exile and reached Malanada Hill. He was extremely thirsty and went to a nearby house in the northwest of Malanada, and asked for drinking water. This house was the Kaduthamśśeri Palace, where Malanada Appūppan, the priest and ruler of the land, was staying. An elderly woman from the house gave Duryodhana, toddy to drink, which was customary at that time as a token of respect. The king understood that there is some divinity to the place and that the people possessed extraordinary powers and were also experts in indigenous medicines. Duryodhana also noticed the 'Kurathāli' (ornament worn by that community) worn by the woman and understood that she belonged to the Kurava community who are forest dwellers. He was quite touched by their hospitality.

To show his gratitude, he sat there on a hill and worshipped Bhagavān Śiva for the welfare of the prajā, or people living in the village. Later, the villagers built Malanada Temple in the same spot where Duryodhana meditated. Unlike other temples, there is no deity or sanctum as such in Malanada temple. Instead, we see a raised platform at the spot where Duryodhana meditated on Bhagavān Śiva. The devotees offer their prayers to this aspect of Duryodhana, where he is engulfed in Śiva Caitanya or the presence of Bhagavān Śiva.

The 'Nandis' on the platform symbolises this aspect of the presence of Śiva.

The annual festival at Malanada is known as 'Malakkuda'. It is celebrated when the terrestrial agricultural activities for a season come to an end, and the paddy cultivation for the next season is about to begin. The beginning of the festival is proclaimed by 'Kodiyettu' (the temple flag hoisting ceremony by ūrālī or priest) on the first Friday of the Malayālam month Meenam. The second Friday of Mīnaṁ is celebrated as 'Malakkuda'. Thus, we have an eight-day festival from Kodiyettu to Malakkuda.

There is another legend behind the eight-day celebration of the festival. Before leaving, Duryodhana tells the head of the community that the Kurukṣetra war will begin soon. He says, "I will come back here victorious within a week. If, after one week, I don't return, consider that I am defeated and died in the war.". Duryodhana also asks him to perform his last rites here considering him as his father. Hence the ūrālī at the Duryodhana temple is a prati-puruṣa, or representative, of Duryodhanā's son.

The temple follows the tradition of ancestral worship. There are thirteen sub-shrines to the temple including one for Duryodhanā's sister Duḥśalā. Interestingly, the temple also pays property tax every year in the name of Duryodhana.

Khātūśyām

Barbarīka or Khātūśyām is mentioned in folktales, in Gujarāt and Rājasthān [9]. After the Lākṣāgrha (wax palace) incident,

the Pāṇḍavās along with their mother Kuntī went into hiding in the forest, deciding to stay away from Hastināpura. As they travelled through the forest, they encountered the rākṣasa siblings, Hiḍimbī (or Hiḍimbā) and Hiḍimba. Bhīma married Hiḍimbī after killing her brother Hiḍimba, who wanted to eat them. In this marriage, a son was born to Bhīma. His name was Ghaṭotkaca. Later Ghaṭotkaca marries Morwī, who is the daughter of a powerful rākṣasa Mur in Prāgjyotiṣpur. Barbarīka is born as the son of Ghaṭotkaca and Morwī. Ghaṭotkaca takes him to Dwāraka to meet Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa. Bhagavān advises Barbarīka to worship and meditate on Goddess Durgā.

Seeing his devotion, Goddess Durgā granted a boon to Barbarīka, giving him three infallible arrows. Mother Durgā also blessed him saying that by using these arrows he would be victorious in all three worlds. When he came back home, the Kurukṣetra war was already declared. Barbarīka, being a warrior, wanted to participate in the war. His mother Morwī asked him, “On whose side will you be fighting?” Barbarīka said that he will first watch the battle for a while and then fight for the losing side.

Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa through his foresight saw Barbarīka coming to participate in the war. Bhagavān decided to test Barbarīka and so disguised himself as a brahmin and sat under a peepal tree, a little away from the battlefield. When Barbarīka saw him, he bowed down to the brahmin. The brahmin asked him where he was going. Barbarīka replied that he was going to the battlefield. He then asked how he would go to war with

just three arrows. Barbarīka replied, "The first arrow would mark the people who need to be protected. The second arrow would mark the people to be killed and the third arrow would kill the ones who need to be killed." Hearing this Bhagavān asked him, "On whose side will you fight?" Barbarīka explained his plans to watch the war first and then join the losing side. Bhagavān then thought, "If this brave man joins the Kaurava side, which is the losing side, then the scene of the whole battlefield would change. If this happened, then Dharma would be destroyed and Adharma would be victorious." Śrī Kṛṣṇa realised that Barbarīka's participation in the war had to be stopped. Bhagavān then showed his true form to Barbarīka and told him that it is necessary to sacrifice a brave Kṣatriyā's head before the battle begins. He then requested Barbarīka's head as a sacrifice. Barbarīka being an ardent devotee of Śrī Kṛṣṇa, agreed without having a second thought. But he asked Śrī Kṛṣṇa for one last wish. He wanted to witness the battle till the end. Śrī Kṛṣṇa granted him this. Bhagavān placed Barbarīka's head at the top of a hill in order for him to watch the battle.

At the end of the war when Barbarīka was asked who won the war, he replied "I could see only the Sudarśana Cakra revolving everywhere, hacking the Kaurava army to pieces. And I saw Draupadī assuming the fierce form of Mahākālī, drinking bowl after bowl of blood, not allowing even one drop to fall on the Earth". Pleased with Barbarīka, Śrī Kṛṣṇa blesses him that he will be worshipped in his form 'śyām' in Kaliyuga. Barbarīka's head was later buried in the land of

Khātū. By Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa's boon, he later came to be worshipped as 'Khātūśyām'.

This is the tale behind the Khātūśyām Temple. However, the character Barbarīka is not mentioned in Vyāsa Mahābhārata. The account of Barbarīka is narrated in detail in Skanda Purāna [10].

Like all the stories mentioned here, there are countless tales in various regions across India. These stories are prime examples of the power of oral traditions down through the ages. These retellings may contain subtle and sometimes gross variations to Vyāsa Mahābhārata, but are nevertheless a relevant part of our culture and are living traditions of Mahābhārata.

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Chapter 12

**STRATEGICAL SILHOUETTE
OF AN EXTRAORDINARY
PEACE MISSION**

If you want peace, then prepare for a war!
Learn the strategies directly from the maestro.

Enter Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa, the ultimate
mastermind whose visionary methods are key to
acquiring Dharma!



Chapter 12

STRATEGICAL SILHOUETTE OF AN EXTRAORDINARY PEACE MISSION

Did you know that Indian Naval Ships (INS) dock at tactically important locations whenever some chief personnel of our Nation is engaged in a diplomatic conversation with another from an unfriendly country? You might be wondering what this has to do with Mahābhārata. We will surely come back to this, but later.

Overture to the Peace Mission

As a prelude, let us briefly navigate through the immediate circumstances that led to this peace mission. Losing the bet to the deceitful games of Śakuni, the five Pāṇḍavas and their wife Draupadī lived in the forest for twelve years facing severe hardships and the thirteenth year incognito at the kingdom of Virāṭa. Having completed the stipulated time of thirteen years in exile, now the Pāṇḍavas could claim back

their rightful share of the kingdom. The Udyoga Parva of Mahābhārata starts here. In Saṃskṛtaṃ, Udyoga means effort or active preparation. Here we could see a very strenuous effort towards 'peace' as well as preparations for 'war', hence the befitting word choice 'Udyoga' Parva by the Sage author. We see war preparations and simultaneously peace options being explored here, in this Parva of the Itihāsa.

Back to the story, a well-learned house priest of the Pañcāla king Drupada is sent as the first delegate to Hastināpura to talk peace. In the meantime, anticipating that the wicked Duryodhana would have no intention to give back the kingdom, the Pāṇḍavas raised an army of seven Akṣauhiṇī. An Akṣauhiṇī is a unit of battle formation consisting of a huge number of chariots, horses, elephants, cavalries, and infantries in particular ratios. Learning about this proactive measure through his spies, Duryodhana also starts gathering his side of the army and raises eleven Akṣauhiṇī.

The Brahmin Purohita messenger reaches Hastināpura and politely demands back half the kingdom to Pāṇḍavas as it was rightfully theirs. Bhīṣma supports him but Karṇa ridicules stating that not even one-fourth of the kingdom will be given back, leave alone half. As not being able to arrive at any decision, king Dhṛtarāṣṭra sends Sañjaya to the Pāṇḍavas as the next step towards negotiation.

Sañjaya reaches the Pāṇḍava camp and conveys that Dhṛtarāṣṭra desires peace and not war. Dharmaputra Yudhiṣṭhira echoes back that they, too, consider peace

superior, and if their kingdom at Indraprastha could be returned, they are willing to pardon every single suffering that they have undergone to date due to the misdoings of the Kauravas. Slipping off from that demand, Sañjaya rather sermonizes Pāṇḍavas on the evil effects of war. “Can happiness be gained with possessions obtained through war? Even if you do not get back your kingdom, you should not abandon the supreme path of Dharma” etc.

Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa intervenes in the conversation and recounts all the misconduct of Kauravas towards Pāṇḍavas, including the disrobing of Draupadī in the court. He expresses that he still desires peace, and would visit the Kauravas to settle matters before a disaster happens. Sañjaya goes back to Hāstinapura.

After that, Kṛṣṇa consults all five brothers and their wife Draupadī to know about their views and get prepared to embark on this peace mission to Hastināpura. Yudhiṣṭhira points out that this mission would mostly be a futile exercise since unprincipled Duryodhana will have no honest wish to return the places they acquired.

The wise Pāṇḍava reckons that Duryodhana might even try to harm Śrī Kṛṣṇa during this visit. Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa agrees that he too understands that this journey to establish peace shall mostly be fruitless, but still, an effort has to be made in all ways to attempt peace before massive destruction happens. Also, he reveals his invincible strength announcing that if Duryodhana heedlessly tries to capture him, he will fight and

burn everything to the ground. Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa undertakes his journey with his chariot equipped with weapons and also ten Mahārathīs and a thousand soldiers accompanying him.

Learning about Śrī Kṛṣṇa's arrival, Dhṛtarāṣṭra arranges for a grand welcome. He keeps many ornamented citadels ready with all riches en route for Kṛṣṇa to rest but all these lavishing gifts were only a pretense to win him over! Knower of all hearts, the Yādava king wilfully brushed aside all these arrangements and went directly to Hastināpura.

Duryodhana had made splendid arrangements for Kṛṣṇa's stay but Kṛṣṇa did not accept his hospitality and went to the house of Vidura for his stay. Vidura was overwhelmed by this singular honour.

The next morning, Vidura expresses the same concern to Kṛṣṇa that this mission was not likely to succeed since Duryodhana was lost to all good counsel.

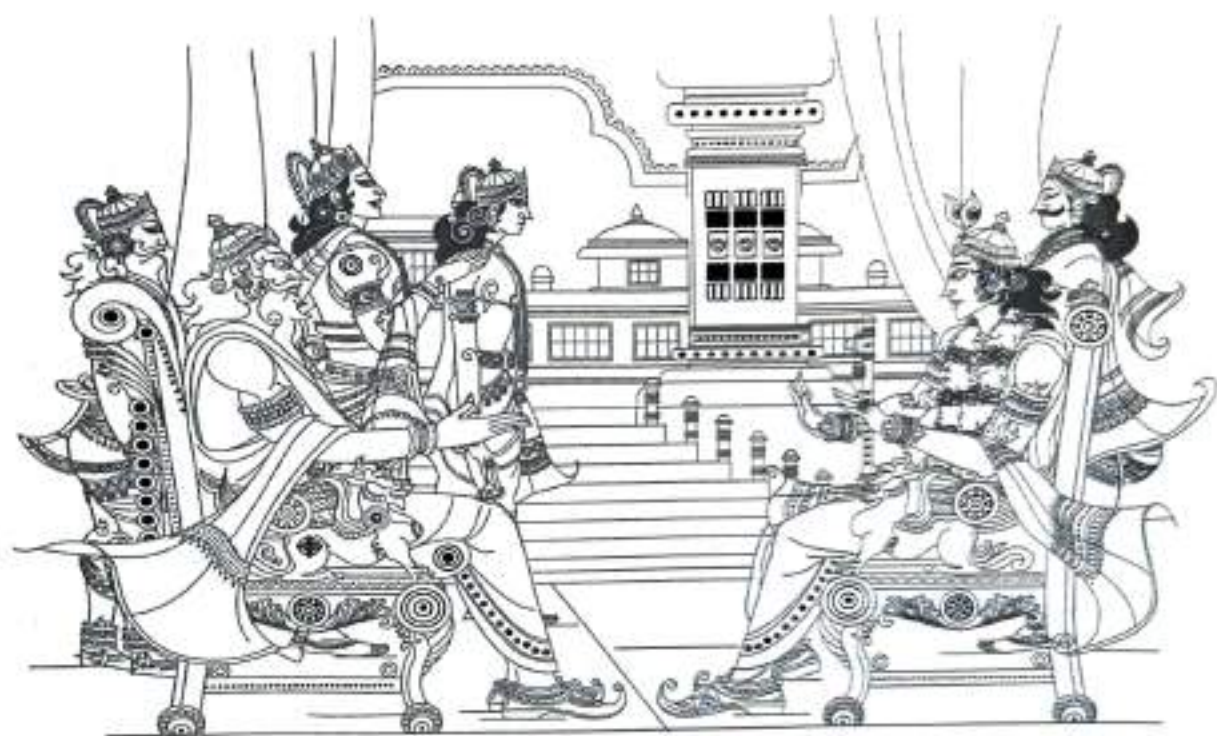
Duryodhana was just eager for war since he thought that with Bhīṣma, Droṇa, Kripa, and Karṇa on his side, the war results would be in his favour. Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa patiently replies that he knows what the Kauravas think.

"I know what effect my words will have on them. Still, I want to save them from imminent death. They all are certain to die in the war. I shall win eternal fame if I can save them through my efforts. Even if I am not unsuccessful, I shall have the consolation that I have done my best efforts. I see the destruction of the Kauravas and I am keen to avoid that. I also want to tell everyone in the court about the great

injustice done to the Pāṇḍavas. War is inevitable, but let everyone know who is responsible for it.”^[1]

Śrī Kṛṣṇa in the court of Kauravas

Next-Day in the royal court, Kṛṣṇa addressed King Dhṛtarāṣṭra stating that the purpose of his visit to Hastināpura is to stop the war by any means. This will avoid an unnecessary massacre of the eighteen Akṣauhiṇī army, Mahārathīs, other warriors, and heroes.



Kṛṣṇa points out the injustice that has been done to the Pāṇḍavas. He exclaimed that if the Kauravas and the Pāṇḍavas lived together peacefully, they would have no rival in the world to challenge the house of the Kurus.

Some thoughtful sentences are worth mentioning: ” I see all the kings gathered here in this august assembly, going into the

jaws of death. Only you are capable of preventing it! Save the world from destruction and let your sons and the Pāṇḍavas live peacefully. Don't let the opportunity slip out of your hands. Therefore, it is my humble request to you, that the kingdom of the Pāṇḍavas should be returned to them."

Listening to this, Dhṛtarāṣṭra just whines that he is powerless since his sons don't listen to him! He asks Kṛṣṇa to talk and convince Duryodhana and Karṇa since even Bhīṣma and Vidura cannot make them see the right path. Kṛṣṇa tries that too by praising Duryodhana, "You are a descendant of a very great family. You are endowed with great wealth and many good qualities. I am not able to understand your unjust treatment of your cousins, Pāṇḍavas. My dear Duryodhana, you should choose the path that may bring happiness to your mother, father, elders, and your teachers. You can make them happy by following the path of the truth and righteousness only."

Bhīṣma, Droṇa, and Vidura also approve of what Kṛṣṇa had said but on hearing such unpalatable advice from Kṛṣṇa, Duryodhana alleges that Kṛṣṇa is partial towards the Pāṇḍavas. He proudly boasts that he is ready to face the war and will not give them half the kingdom or five villages or even that much land that the point of a sharp needle can hold.

Though Kṛṣṇa gets angry at the thoughtless words of Duryodhana, he makes another try as well and reaffirms all unrighteous actions done earlier, like plotting to burn Pāṇḍavas in a wax palace, deceitful gambling, trying to

disrobe Draupadī, insulting words of Duḥśāsana and Karna, etc.

Kṛṣṇa holds everybody in that assembly responsible for such a situation by pampering and not correcting Duryodhana. Kṛṣṇa says, “A person may be abandoned for the sake of a family, a family may be sacrificed for the sake of a village, the village may be sacrificed for the sake of a Nation. For the sake of one’s soul, the entire world may be forsaken.” Duryodhana walks out of the assembly hall full of rage along with his brother Duḥśāsana.

Kṛṣṇa continued, “Does it not happen occasionally that a village is abandoned so that the country may be saved? I am afraid you will have to sacrifice Duryodhana if you want to save your race. That is the only way.” [2]

Now Dhṛtarāṣṭra gave it another whirl by calling Gāndhārī thinking perhaps Duryodhana may listen to his mother. Still, Duryodhana remains rock-ribbed, disregards his mother’s words, and leaves the assembly hall without speaking.

Meanwhile, outside, Duryodhana, Duḥśāsana, Karna, and Śakuni secretly conspire among themselves to capture and imprison Śrī Kṛṣṇa. Sātyaki, who accompanied Mādhava, was very alert. He understood the evil plan of the wicked four and immediately alerted their soldiers at the main gate to get ready for a battle ambush and gave a hint of the scheme to Śrī Kṛṣṇa.

Then he revealed it to Dhṛtarāṣṭra and Vidura also, laughingly. They were taken aback, and at the command of

Dhṛtarāṣṭra, Vidura brings Duryodhana and his brothers back to the assembly. Both Dhṛtarāṣṭra and Vidura again described the greatness of Śrī Kṛṣṇa and advised him to take the path of virtue.

Śrī Kṛṣṇa scoffs at Duryodhana for his ignorance in trying to seize him saying that Duryodhana out of his folly considers Kṛṣṇa as a single person, while he is everything in the universe. Kṛṣṇa laughs out loud and all Gods and all Suns and everything emerge from him, in his Viśvarūpa.

His radiant form had many arms that carried many weapons. Except for Droṇa, Bhīṣma, Vidura, Sañjaya, and other Ṛṣis, everybody got frightened at this terrible form and closed their eyes. Shortly after, Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa took permission from Ṛṣis and left the court to meet his paternal aunt Kuntī.

Insights and Analysis of Śrī Kṛṣṇa's peace mission

This episode might seem trivial, but it's not! Comprehending this part is decisive in obtaining a holistic and unambiguous understanding of the Itihāsa. Let us have a careful glance through the event and take home a few of our learnings.

1. The first and foremost thing to appreciate is the 'spare no effort' attempt of Śrī Kṛṣṇa to establish peace amongst the cousin brothers. Sañjaya's message from Dhṛtarāṣṭra was clear that they (Kauravas) do not want a war to happen but as well they have the least intention to give back any part of the empire.

As Śrī Kṛṣṇa prepares to go as a Pāṇḍava messenger, Yudhiṣṭhira ponders over the utility of such a mission. He

believes that the wicked Duryodhana will not give back any land no matter who goes for the negotiation. When that is the case, why should Kṛṣṇa take up this mission? Later, this same concern is shared by the Dharmic icon Vidura too.

Bhagavān replies to both of them that he too knows the certainty that Duryodhana won't lend an ear to his peace talk nor would he give back the kingdom share; nevertheless, before proceeding to a war that shall bring about colossal damage to both sides, it would be ideal to try for a peaceful resolution. At least this act would leave a message to our future generations that we tried our best for peace.

Secondly, if we observe the conversation of Śrī Kṛṣṇa in the court of the Kauravas, we can see him trying in all ways to avoid the war. This audacious step taken by Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa is very firm evidence against the misrepresentation of him as one who sought war and instigated Arjuna towards it.

Completely wrong! In all his honesty, he cared for both sides and dedicated himself to achieving peace even when knowing the probable chances for the peace attempt to work out was next to nothing!

2. Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa is rightly warned by Yudhiṣṭhira in a prior conversation to his peace mission, that Duryodhana is wickedness personified and that he would even go to the extent of harming the messenger, Kṛṣṇa.

Bhagavān acknowledges the concern and says that if the Kauravas try such a foolish experiment, it will bring destruction to them. The same expected untoward attempt happens and we all know that Śrī Kṛṣṇa exhibited his

Viśvarūpa (all-encompassing form). Keeping aside this Godly spectacle, we could even find a political strategy hidden beneath.

There are ten Mahārathīs and thousand soldiers travel along with Kṛṣṇa when he goes on the peace mission. And Mahābhārata particularly mentions that Kṛṣṇa has his chariot fully equipped with arms if in case required. You will be surprised to learn that a Mahārathī is a warrior who can fight over seven lakh warriors simultaneously.

Karṇa, Bhīṣma, Rāvaṇa, Abhimanyu, Droṇa, Kumbhakarṇa, etc. were Mahārathīs. You will be even more surprised to learn that, of the ten Mahārathīs who accompany Śrī Kṛṣṇa, one is the chief army general Sātyaki who defeats even Karṇa in the Kurukṣetra war.

Sātyaki is present there with Kṛṣṇa throughout the peace talks. He is always alert and prepares his army outside when he senses Duryodhana might try to capture Kṛṣṇa.

Such political precautionary measures were pursued during this negotiation meeting. As mentioned in the introduction, even today, Indian Naval Ships are docked at strategic locations whenever some chief personnel of our Nation is engaged in a diplomatic conversation with another from an unfriendly country.

Thousands of years have passed since the Mahābhārata, but still, there are many examples of similar ideals, practices, and strategies practised today! ^[3] We can only bow down humbly to the great visionary Maharṣi Vyāsa in wonderment.

3. As the peace mission concludes without any positive outcome, Śrī Kṛṣṇa tells Dhṛtarāṣṭra,

त्यजेत्कुलार्थे पुरुषं ग्रामस्यार्थे कुलं त्यजेत्
ग्रामं जनपदस्यार्थे आत्मार्थे पृथिवीं त्यजेत्

*tyajetkulārthe puruṣaṁ grāmasyārthe kulam tyajet
grāmaṁ janapadasyārthe ātmārthe pṛthivīm tyajet*

Mahābhārata 05.126.48

“A person may be abandoned for the sake of the family, a family may be sacrificed for the sake of a village, and a village may be sacrificed for the sake of a Nation. For the sake of one’s soul, the entire world may be forsaken.”

Family prevails over the individual; Village over family; Nation over Village; When the emptiness of worldly pleasures is comprehended through experience and wisdom, one may give them up.

Kṛṣṇa is not the first person who advocates this idea in Mahābhārata. More than twice, the same śloka is recited in different instances, implying that the underlying idea could be a bedrock philosophy during Mahābhārata times.

A careful glance would show the essence of Indian Culture in this verse. The Dharmic view of a greater good allows one to denounce relatively minor things and the spiritual view of complete renunciation leads one to Divinity.

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Chapter 13

**YĀJÑASENI:
A WOMAN FROM FIRE**

With a bold heart, even the most daunting
obstacles can be vanquished.

Story of Yājñaseni stands a testament to the
strength and resilience of a woman. Her legacy
illuminates the path for all who seek to emulate
her example.



History has proven ample times that, without external opportunities and security, one needs self-confidence to push to the forefront and accomplish great deeds. Strong and confident women have been present in all spheres of our society, be it politics, arts, business, law and order, or defence. Self-confidence is indisputably the one key that unlocks this infinite potential in them. Amma says, "Though there are differences in outlook, approach, and activities of men and women, bound by time, place, and culture, courageous women have lived in every age. They have broken out of the cages that were imposed on them. Rāni Padminī, Hathi Rāni, Mirābai, and Jhānsi Rāni represent such valour and purity."



Everyone should remember these icons and remember them constantly, to let it sink into their minds that there is infinite

potential in women. There is a tradition that calls for just that and hails the memory of our heroes of ancient times.

अहल्या द्रौपदी कुन्ती तारा मन्दोदरी तथा ।
पञ्च कन्याः स्मरेन्नित्यं महापातक नाशनम् ॥

*ahalyā draupadī kuntī tārā mandodarī tathā.
pañca kanyāḥ smarennityaṁ mahāpātaka nāśanam.*

Ahalya, Draupadī, Kuntī, Tārā and Maṇḍodarī. Invoking the memory of these five women every morning before dawn, protects one from great sins.

Let us inspire ourselves from the life of Draupadī and see why she is an inspiration for women today, why she is *prātaḥ smaraṇīya* (to be remembered in the morning).

In Āraṇya Parva, Satyabhāma asks Draupadī how she can keep the mighty personalities of the Pāṇḍavās in check and how they always look toward her and do her bidding. Draupadī's response here reveals her managerial capabilities. She relates to Satyabhāma her life routines, the hard work in the household, the responsibilities she manages, and the virtues she follows. She manages thousands of servants and knows each one by name, the work they do, and the garments they wore. She knew every fine detail about the king's revenue and expenditure. In this manner, she knew everything about the Pāṇḍavas.

She catered to each Pāṇḍava as advised by Maharṣi Nārada. Once, Maharṣi visited the Pāṇḍavas at Khāṇḍavaprastha and gave his advice regarding their marriage. He told the Pāṇḍavās that Draupadī should live with one husband per

year. Draupadī strictly followed this advice. When she is with one husband, she dedicates herself to him only and does not even think of the others. In this manner, she catered to each husband equally and upheld her *pātivratyaṃ* (roughly means chastity in English). There is a popular misconceived notion of this polyandrous relationship - the question of her *pātivratyaṃ*. It is equally pertinent today as when Karṇa insulted her in the Kaurava court during the game of dice. Karṇa calls her a *veśya* (courtesan) unworthy of a queen's Dharma because she is wife to five husbands. But Draupadī's conduct with her husbands is not comparable in this manner. Draupadī upholds her *pātivratyaṃ* to each husband, as advised by Maharṣi Nārada. Karṇa may also be unaware that she did not choose to have five husbands. It was a *Niyogā* or destiny and divine will. She did not have a husband in her previous birth; hence she meditated on Bhagavān Parameśwara. When Bhagavān offered her a boon, she asked for a husband with all qualities. But, she repeated this five times, out of overflowing desire and Bhagavān granted that she would have five worthy husbands. Thus, it was her *niyoga* to have five husbands.

Furthermore, if Karṇa was right about Draupadī, she would have left the Pāṇdavas after the game of dice and joined Duryodhana to enjoy the pleasures of life and continued in Hastināpura. But, during the game of dice, when her husband bet on her and lost, she continued to hold on to the Dharma of a devoted wife. She did not leave the Pāṇdavas for their deeds, but instead saved them all and continued her Dharma.

Today, in addition to being an effective manager, there is a dire need to be able to balance between home and career. Chasing success in their careers, both women and men fall prey to a poorly managed home and compromise their family life. Here Draupadī's extraordinary managerial capacity is simply awe-inspiring. Is it not admirable that amidst all her tasks as Queen, she never went back on her responsibilities as a life partner, that too with five husbands?

Another astounding quality of Draupadī is her *vipattidhairya*, courage in crisis. This is a hard to obtain yet essential life skill. We often find ourselves dejected and depressed after a hard traumatic event. We get drenched in fear, horrified and unable to think clearly in such circumstances. It may be abuse, theft, robbery, or even a life-threatening experience. Draupadī had to deal with all these and more, many times over. Yet she did not lose herself in the moment or afterwards. She was not lost in depression or dejected enough to retire from life or move on with a grudge towards Bhagavān or life itself.

Be it when Jayadratha abducted her from their home in Kāmākhyā forest, or when Kīcaka approached her in King Virāta's palace, Draupadī did not shudder, nor was she miserable, dejected, or afraid. She did not bow down in shame or out of fear. When Jayadratha abducted her, she kept warning him about the strength and courage of her husband. She advised him to release her and urged him to beg for their forgiveness. In the case of Kīcaka, she had to face him alone in many situations. Even Queen Sudhesna, who

she was serving at King Virāta's palace, sided with Kīcaka. With the help of the queen, Kīcaka made Draupadī visit him in his quarters. He proposed to her again, and when she did not accept, tried to take her by force. Draupadī managed to escape the subjugation, but could not find protection or help in any way. Yet still, her confidence did not waver. When she had no choice left, Draupadī convinced Bhīma to kill him, as Kīcaka rightly deserved. The same vipatti-dhairya is reflected in the game of dice as well. Though she laments in the court when no one answers her, she holds it together, addressing the court all the while, and finally manages to save the day and rescue her husbands. Such was the endless courage and confidence of Yājñaseni.

We must realise that this courage and confidence are there in each one of us, women and men. Ammā says, "Women are not weak. Her natural compassion and sympathy have too often been misinterpreted as weakness." It is always left to us to take that decision, relinquish fear and stand tall in the face of dire situations. Ammā tells the story of an eagle who thought it was a chicken. Once, by chance, a baby eagle found itself living amongst a brood of chicks. The mother hen raised it in the same way she raised her own offspring. Like the chicks, the young eagle grew up foraging the ground for worms. The eagle thought itself a mere chicken, ignorant of its ability to fly and soar into the air. One day, another eagle noticed this eagle fledgling with the chicks. When it was alone, the 'sky eagle' approached the 'chicken eagle' and brought it to a lake. The 'sky eagle' said, "My child, don't

you know who you are? Here, look at me, and now look at your own reflection in the water. Like me, you too are an eagle with the ability to soar in the sky - not an earth-bound chicken.” Gradually the eagle realised its strength, and then, without much delay, spread its wings and soared into the sky.

Ammā says, “The vast sky is the eagle’s birthright. In the same way, a woman has the potential to soar into the endless sky of strength and freedom. But before this freedom can become a reality, women must prepare themselves through steady effort. It is the thought that she is powerless and saddled by numerous limitations and weaknesses that inhibit her. She must first eliminate such thinking”. Today, when the women of the world strive for empowerment, Draupadī is a true role model for self-growth. She is representative of how strong a presence women can be. During the game of dice, Draupadī stood at her most desperate self in the middle of the Kaurava court. When all hope died, she still did not give in. Instead, she closed her eyes and prayed to her dear Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa. Her faith and devotion were so strong and intense, that Bhagavān came to her aid and rescued her. Alongside her strong devotion, courage, and managerial capabilities, she had vast knowledge and wisdom on Dharma and the Śāstrās. When the Pāṇdavas were leaving for the forest after the game of dice, the wise Vidura, who is Dharmadeva taken birth, told Yudhiṣṭhira, “Draupadī is *dharmārthakuśalā dharmacārīṇī*” meaning, “Draupadī always follows the path of Dharma and is skilled in the ways of Dharma and Artha”. What better validation is required when the God of Dharma himself extols the Dhārmic wisdom of Draupadī?

Draupadī's life is a lesson for men as well. It reveals how men should be and should not be. It reveals the shamelessness, naivety, and sheer lack of morals in a man who misbehaves with women, and what happens in the end to such men. Therefore, remembering her would be beneficial for both men and women. A truly progressive society is said to be one where women are safe, where they are free, and where they flourish and prosper. All of us have a role to play if we are to make that progress. To that end, let us remember Draupadī Devī. Let us begin by invoking her memory every morning. And through her let us embrace Mahābhārata all the more, to fulfil the purpose of life and living.

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Chapter 14

**DEATH AND
DEATHLESSNESS**

Do we all have to die no matter what we do or
how hard we try?

Not necessarily!

There is a possibility to transcend death and
embrace deathlessness.



DEATH AND DEATHLESSNESS

Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad bestows upon us, a beautiful mantra that is chanted by millions, even now after thousands of years of its inception.

ॐ असतो मा सद्गमय ।

तमसो मा ज्योतिर्गमय ।

मृत्योर्मा अमृतं गमय ।^[1]

Om Asato Maa Sadgamaya |

Tamaso Maa Jyotir-Gamaya |

Mrtyor-Maa Amrtam Gamaya |

In most simple terms, the meaning of the prayer would be,

“Lead me from the asat to sat.

Lead me from darkness to light.

Lead me from death to immortality.”

This is not a prayer imploring for worldly things like food, health, glory, fame or even heaven. This is a sincere

admission by one, of his sense of limitedness and a heartfelt cry seeking assistance to transcend such limitedness^[2]. The third line, '*mṛtyormā amṛtaṁ gamaya*' means, 'Lead me from death to immortality'. It is a prayer to realize the truth that "I am deathless since I was never born. I am not the body, not the mind, and not the intellect, but the eternal, blissful consciousness that serves as the substratum of all creation." This is a journey of knowledge from what we have misunderstood to be ourselves to what truly is ourselves. A journey from Death to Deathlessness.

Mahābhārata conspicuously delineates this idea of the journey from death to deathlessness in the penultimate Parva 'Mahāprasthānika Parva'. 'Mahā' means great and 'Prasthānam' means journey or departure^[3]. This Parva narrates the departure of the Pāṇḍavas for the Himālayas and their deaths, one after another.

Having ruled the kingdom for many years after the Kurukṣetra war, the Pāṇḍavas decided to undertake the great departure. They instated Parīkṣit as the next King of the Kurus and Yudhiṣṭhira instructed that their funeral ceremonies be performed after the departure. A lot of jewels, horses, cattle, garments, etc., were given away to charity. Wearing just tree barks, the five Pāṇḍavas and Draupadī departed. This bore a striking resemblance to how they left the kingdom much earlier, after being defeated in the game of dice. Yudhiṣṭhira walked in front, followed by Bhīma. Arjuna came after him, followed by the twins in the right order, and then the beautiful Draupadī at the back. A dog later joined them as the seventh.

Immersing in yoga, following the dharma of renunciation, they passed through many kingdoms and crossed many rivers and mountains. They saw Dwāraka flooded by the ocean when they travelled in the southwestern direction. All of them fasted and headed in the northern direction and saw the giant Himālayas. Suddenly Draupadī fell to the ground.

Bhīma was shocked seeing that and spoke to Dharmarāj Yudhiṣṭhira. "This princess never committed an act of adharma. O king! Why has Draupadī fallen down on the ground?" Yudhiṣṭhira replied, "O Bhīma! She had a great partiality for Arjuna and she reaped the fruits of that." Having said this, the king who was Dharma's son didn't look back and kept walking. Very soon the intelligent Sahadeva also fell down. Bhīma again spoke to the king. "Sahadeva served all of us without any pride. Why has he fallen down?" Yudhiṣṭhira replied, "He thought that there was no one to equal him in wisdom. O Bhīma! It is because of that lapse that he has fallen down." They continued their journey leaving Sahadeva. Next to fall was Nakula. Bhīma asked Dharmaputra very eagerly, "What has Nakula done for his collapse because he always had Dharma in his soul and he always adhered to it?" Yudhiṣṭhira thought but without stopping his walk, answered, "Nakula indeed possessed dharma in his soul and was supreme among all the intelligent ones. But he held a view that there was no one equalling his beauty. O Vṛkodara, this led to his fall. Anything ordained for a person is bound to happen". The three of them continued to tread the mountains accompanied by the dog. In a short while, the

unparalleled war hero, Arjuna also was tormented by grief and fell down helplessly. Bhīma expressed his surprise, "I cannot even remember any falsehood that this great-souled one has wilfully uttered. What is the transgression, as a result of which, he has fallen down on the ground like this?" Yudhiṣṭhira said with a sigh, "Arjuna always said that he would burn down the enemy in a single day. Though he was proud of his valour, he wasn't able to accomplish that. He disrespected all the other valorous warriors. That is the reason why he has fallen down." They continued walking. Now it was Bhīmasena himself who fell down. Before embracing death, lying on the ground he spoke to the elder brother, "O King, look at me, what is the reason I have fallen down? If you know, then tell me." Yudhiṣṭhira knew the answer to that too, he said "O Bhīma you ate too much and you always boasted about your strength. You disrespected others. That is the reason you have fallen down on the ground." Having said this, the mighty-armed King proceeded without looking back. The dog alone followed him.

As he walked, Lord Indra arrived before him on a divine chariot and instructed Yudhiṣṭhira to ascend the chariot. Dharmāraja was overcome by grief having seen his brothers and wife fall down. So he requested Indra to take them also to Swarga, "O lord of the Gods! Without my brothers, I do not desire to go to heaven. Princess Draupadī was also delicate and deserved happiness. Let her also come with us." To this, Indra Deva replied that all of them had to cast aside their human bodies but reached the heavens while Yudhiṣṭhira could ascend to Swarga in this body itself and there was no

reason to grieve. The surviving Pāṇḍava thoughtfully said, “O lord of past and present, this dog has devotedly followed me so far, so he should also be taken along with me. Because of compassion, this is my view.” Indra wasn’t so happy with that proposition and said, “O king! You will now obtain immortality, prosperity like mine, all kinds of great fame, and the happiness of Swarga Loka. Abandon this dog. There is no lack of compassion in this.” However, Yudhiṣṭhira was stubborn in his view, “How can a noble person perform an ignoble act? I do not want prosperity that comes about by abandoning those who are devoted to me.” Indra again tried to convince Dharmaputra that there was no lack of compassion in abandoning a dog. But Yudhiṣṭhira held firm and was even ready to forsake heaven for this dog. At that point, the dog that had followed him changed its form into Dharma Deva himself. It was another test to check the *dharmaniratattvam* (steadfastness in Dharma) of the eldest Pāṇḍava. Having passed the test, the Pāṇḍava ascended the chariot which travelled swiftly to the heavens.

There are at least two significant lessons that are demonstrated in this beautiful episode. One is the boundless compassion of the eldest Pāṇḍava. His unbending concern and compassion for another being and the impeccable clarity of Dharma that earned him this immortality stature. But it is also important to mention the weaknesses that caused the others to fall along with the qualities that earned deathlessness to the eldest Pāṇḍava. Through this parva, Bhagavān Vyāsa demarcates between death and deathlessness. All the remaining Pāṇḍavas and their wife succumbed to death because of a simple three-

letter word 'ego'. For one it was the ego of beauty while for another it was an ego of strength. One had favouritism, while one vaunted himself, and so on. Even though the Pāṇḍavas as protagonists of the Itihāsa are always shown in the light of Dharma, the subtle identifications of their minds are showcased here. In simple terms, 'mine' and 'my' thoughts led them to death while 'selflessness' led one to deathlessness.

It is worth recollecting a story narrated by Rāma Tīrtha from his famous book 'In Woods of God Realization'^[4]. Once there was a sculptor who was so adept at making his own statues to such perfection that you could not tell the duplicate from the original. When he knew that Death was coming for him, he made his own replica a dozen times. The messenger of Death came but could not differentiate the real person from his creations, and so left without taking him. However, he came back after consultation with the God of Death and remarked, "Dear, you are wonderfully clever and talented. Why, that is just the way you have made these figures, but there is one thing wherein you have erred, there is just one fault, alas!" The man jumped up and shouted "In what? In what have I erred?" And the assistant of Death caught hold of him and said, "Just this was your error". The little imp of the doer self is claimed by death.

Mahābhārata itself validates this motif. In Aśvamedha Parva, Bhagavān Vāsudeva himself says,

द्व्यक्षरस्तु भवेन्मृत्युस्त्र्यक्षरं ब्रह्म शाश्वतम्
ममेति द्व्यक्षरो मृत्युर्नममेति च शाश्वतम्

*dyakṣarastu bhavenmrtyustryakṣaram brahma śāśvatam
mameiti dyakṣaro mrtyurnamameti ca śāśvatam*

Mahābhārata 14.13.03

This means that a two-letter Sanskrit word leads one to death while a three-letter Sanskrit word leads one to Immortality. The two-letter word is 'मम' or 'Mama' which means 'mine' and the three-letter word is 'नमम' or 'Namama', meaning 'not mine'. As long as we entertain the thought of 'I' and everything as 'mine', apparently, we are treading the path to death and when the idea of 'I' and 'mine' fades, there evidently is nothing to die and one becomes deathless.

Isn't it true we have shrunk so much into a peanut of our own likes and dislikes? As long as we feel we are the most important thing in the world, we cannot really appreciate the world around us. We turn out like a horse with blinkers and all we see is ourselves apart from everything else. Yes, we are approaching death.

Ammā or Śrī Mātā Amritānandamayī Devī narrates a beautiful story.

One full moon night during the spring season Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa came to dance with the gopīs. The gopīs were beloved of Bhagavān Śrī Kṛṣṇa. One gopī asked, "Bhagavān, even though there are so many beautiful and fragrant flowers in Vṛndāvan, why do you like the lotus and tulasī so much?" Bhagavān replied, "These are not ordinary flowers; they are the flowers of self-sacrifice." Kṛṣṇa then narrated to them the story behind the lotus and tulasī.

Once a little dirt clod and a dry leaf were playing hide and seek. They came to know that the Lord of Vṛndāvan was coming their way. If one lies in His path and touches His feet, it is enough to gain liberation. The little clod and dry leaf discussed with each other, “Why don’t we go and wait on the path?” So they went and saved themselves a spot on the Lord’s path. But soon a gopī came and swept away the dry leaf and another gopī kicked away the dirt clod saying, “Where did this dirt clod come from in the path of Bhagavān?”

Poor things. With whom could the little dirt clod and dry leaf share their sorrows? The dirt clod said, “No one likes us. Wherever we go, they see us as dirty and useless. What is the point in living when we are just a burden to Mother Earth? It is better to pray to be reborn as a flower or grain of sand on Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa’s path and put an end to this life.” But the dry leaf replied, “It is due to our karma that we received this birth. Still, we have been lucky enough to hear about Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa. But if we kill ourselves, the bad karma that we get from that action might even prevent us from hearing the Bhagavān’s word in our next birth. So, it is better that we make use of this life that God has given us and be useful to someone before dying.” As they brooded over their sorrows, noon came and the sun’s light cast down like fire. But for those who are burning in the fire of sorrow, the external sunlight does not feel hot at all. Suddenly they heard the sound of someone crying. When they looked around they saw a black seed. The dirt clod asked, “Who are you? Why

are you crying? I am a lotus seed and I am about to die from the scorching heat. If only there were someone who could push me into the pond, then I would be saved.”

The dirt clod replied, “If I come in contact with water then I will dissolve into nothingness, but that is okay because at least you will be saved. Let me be of that much use to the world.” Saying so, the little dirt clod took the seed and rolled into the pond. After his friend left, the dry leaf’s sorrow doubled. Suddenly he heard a soft cry. He found a seed even smaller than a mustard seed. “Why are you crying?”, the leaf asked. The seed replied, “I am a tulasī seed. I am about to die in the heat of the sun. I am crying and praying to God to give me some shade.” “Oh, let me be of some use to you”, said the dry leaf. And it covered the tiny tulasī seed. The leaf protected the seed from the sun, wind, snow, and rain and was finally powdered into nothing. Bhagavān Kṛṣṇa concluded the story to the gopīs, “My dear ones when I see the tulasī and lotus, I remember the sacrifice of the dirt clod and dry leaf.”

Amma says, “We all have the feeling of I and mine just like the dirt clod and dry leaf. They are impure and unwanted wherever they go. It is because of this ego and attachment that we are rejected. The feelings of I and mine are also the reason why we can never experience the presence of God. When we are able to kill this ego and attachment for the sake of removing another’s sorrow then we become the beloved of God. We remain inseparable from God. The dirt clod is a hard mass of vāsanās or negative tendencies. When it comes

into contact with the water of love and devotion it dissolves into nothingness. Only then will the flowers of selflessness blossom. In the same way, the dry leaf represents the fallen leaves of the past. When this leaf disintegrates into nothing, it becomes the fertilizer for the ripe fruits of the present moment.”

Understanding the difference between death and deathlessness, let us resolve to shed our egos and attachments. Let us at least try to lend an ear to the concern of another human being at least, if we cannot rise to the level of Yudhiṣṭhira who would forsake heaven for a dog! Let us slowly move from Death to Deathlessness.

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Chapter 15

THE GOAL OF LIFE

As individuals, we often set for ourselves a multitude of goals, pursuing them with relentless fervour. But have we ever stopped to ponder the deeper meaning and purpose of our pursuits?

Isn't it high time to do that?



Chapter 15

THE GOAL OF LIFE

There is a popular notion that Sanātana Dharma is against money making or the attainment of fame and glory. But in fact, Sanātana Dharma has never been against making such goals, or leading a good life like that. Sanātana Dharma was never against becoming wealthy, to build up a flourishing business, to expand and start branches all over the world! No!

Taittirīya Upaniṣad discusses a particular Sādhana known as Avahanti homaṃ. Avahanti homaṃ is actually done for four things,

1. Dhanaprāpti (Obtaining wealth)
2. Cittaśuddhi (Obtaining purity of mind, a virtuous mind, Dharmic mind)
3. Jñānaprāpti (Obtaining knowledge)
4. Śiṣyaprāpti (Obtaining students to share the knowledge)

There is a significance in the above order. Money (Dhanaprāpti) is the first. Because money is required to

perform karma or even karma yoga. We need wealth in the first place, if we need to work towards the well being of society. Even for spending to fulfil our own desires, we should also care about society. So that is why money is mentioned first.

Once we obtain money, we should then use this wealth in such a way that it leads to a pure mind. With that pure mind, we should obtain knowledge. Then we should teach others to preserve the paramparā.

Why do we have children? It is also to preserve the paramparā, right? They are an extension of us, in a sense. The son or daughter are the extension of the parents. Whatever we do is inclusive of this aspect, even though we don't speak about it. Even knowledge, once we attain it, has to be shared with, to keep the paramparā. So that the paramparā, the tradition continues.

The Upaniṣad says, "*tatomesriyamavaha*". After that, bring Lakṣmī Devī, Goddess of prosperity to me. After what? *tata*, after that here means after gaining intelligence. This intelligence, is not the Jñānaprāpti we discussed earlier, but rather a worldly literacy that we need before setting out with our goals. After gaining intelligence? Why? Because money is dangerous in the hands of an unintelligent person. So one should gain money only after gaining intelligence, since prosperity to an unwise man is surely a cause of evil. We have so many examples in the world for that. One must have knowledge of dharma. The Dharmaśāstra in our tradition clearly tells us what to use money for and what not to. Hence knowledge of dharmaśāstra is needed before one gets money.

Today, parents give pocket money to their children. Perhaps a small amount is okay. However, giving more than what they need is dangerous. The parents think that giving money to their children so that they can eat or drink what they like, is an expression of love. But the truth is, most children neither have the maturity nor discernment to spend money on purposeful things. Can we blame children if they use the money to indulge in unhealthy habits such as cigarettes, drugs, or alcohol? Especially with peer pressure and deterioration of moral and spiritual values, this is very likely to happen.

However, Sanātana Dharma calls for making and spending money by means of Dharma. A person knowledgeable of dharmaśāstra is immediately educated or made aware of how to use money. We consider money as Lakṣmī Devī herself, and this automatically brings in a judiciousness in the way we spend money. Hence the only thing that Hindu śāstras propose is to get educated on how to use money. Primarily we find that earning plenty and giving plenty is the Vedic point of view.

For most success means excelling in school, and then graduating from a prestigious university, maybe going to Harvard for higher studies. For some others it is nothing more than going abroad, having one's own business, and others still a house is also a hallmark of success. A poor man may say, my dream is to have my own tea shop, vegetable shop, fruit stall or pantrolly.

Today, our society reinforces these views of success. Parental love equates to one's performance in school. Today employment in large corporations hinges on which university one graduates from, instead of being skilled or good at the job. So to many, mere success is not sufficient, it has to be the cream of creams. Medals and trophies reinforce the belief that we must thrive for the best. Emblems of cars, the colour of credit cards, or the coat of arms of universities glorify their positions in the marketplace. So in our surge towards excellence we compete, not collaborate, in advancing our own causes. We trample over others and forsake the spirit of togetherness. Worse, we disregard time honoured values like faith, compassion, love, integrity, politeness, truthfulness and loyalty. As a result, we are unable to accept, tolerate and manage failure. And much to our own disappointment, money, material possession and fame are the only yardsticks of our success. The neighbourhood and locality in which we reside, and our job titles are external manifestations of our achievement. The society then compartmentalises us into prince or pauper, royalty or a commoner.

Our ancient R̥ṣis declared that any human being in this world is expected to achieve four things in life - Dharma, Artha, Kāma and Mokṣa. So the correct sequence is as follows. As normal, ordinary human beings, we have Kāma. We have desires. Logically, desires should not result in a deterioration of our health. Healthy food, health thoughts, healthy habits etc. When your thoughts are healthy, when your thinking is healthy, when your body is healthy, when your intellect is

healthy, it becomes the best instrument to perform action in the world. That's what we call a sound mind in a sound body. So, using a sound body, mind and intellect, we achieve success, fame, money in life which is called Artha.

We use this success, the money we make, for Dharmic purposes. And ultimately this leads to Mokṣa. And what is this Mokṣa? Don't think about the ultimate state of self-realization. Let us forget that for some time. For the time being, let Mokṣa mean an inner independence, a peace, a happiness within. To be able to relax and enjoy life, take that as mokṣa. Now, on the contrary, what happens in society today? People are always dragging on in their life. Dragging implies that it's a huge burden they are carrying throughout their life, especially in old age. They become totally helpless. Confined within the four walls of an apartment or a flat or a care home. And, you are overburdened with thoughts and emotions, the past simply gushes in. The future is filled with anxiety and you have no present. You have no life. So that's why you need to just create some space within so that you can feel peaceful. You can relax, you can enjoy your moments. And that is the goal of life. That should be the goal of life.

However today, when a student comes out of a university such as IIT, IIM, or one of the reputable universities abroad, the idea he or she gets as the goal of life, is Kāma. The goal of life is Kāma, desire. I have to fulfill desires, all my desires. Whatever it is. No discernment. Big car, big house, big screens etc. And to achieve Kāma, we need Artha, money or success. How to make money or success? For money,

you justify whatever means you follow. You pursue and say that it is all Dharma these days. For example, you take bribes and say that it is Dharma these days as everyone else does it. So, what's wrong? Though people don't realise, there is a consequence to adharma. Enjoyment, happiness, peace, or the mokṣa we defined, has completely gone out the door.

Here is where Mahābhārata becomes relevant. No literary work ever in the history of mankind can be compared to this glorious text. It exposes us to every aspect of Dharma. Every aspect of life. How to live. What is victory? What is failure? Who are you? What is the goal? The Itihāsa shows us that all that you win in life, all the victories, all the accomplishments ultimately account to nothing. Maharṣi Vyāsa summarizes the essence of this great itihāsa in four verses at the end. These verses are known as 'Bhārata Sāvitrī'. It is traditionally hailed that reading these verses have the same benefit as reading the entire Mahābhārata.

मातापितृसहस्राणि पुत्रदारशतानि च
 संसारेष्वनुभूतानि यान्ति यास्यन्ति चापरे
 हर्षस्थानसहस्राणि भयस्थानशतानि च
 दिवसे दिवसे मूढमाविशन्ति न पण्डितम्
 ऊर्ध्वबाहुर्विरौम्येष न च कश्चिच्छृणोति मे
 धर्मादर्थश्च कामश्च स किमर्थं न सेव्यते
 न जातु कामात्र भयात्र लोभाद्धर्मं त्यजेज्जीवितस्यापि हेतोः
 नित्यो धर्मः सुखदुःखे त्वनित्ये; जीवो नित्यो हेतुरस्य त्वनित्यः

*mātāpitrśahasrāṇi putradāraśatāni ca
 saṁsāreṣvanubhūtāni yānti yāsyanti cāpare*

*harṣasthānasahasrāṇi bhayasthānaśatāni ca
 divase divase mūḍhamāviśanti na paṇḍitam
 ūrdhvaabāhurviraumyeṣa na ca kaścicchṛṇoti me
 dharmādarthaśca kāmāśca sa kimartham na sevate
 na jātu kāmānna bhayānna lobhā; ddharmam
 tyajejjīvitasyāpi hetoḥ
 nityo dharmah sukhaduḥkhe tvanitye; jīvo nityo heturasya
 tvanityah*

Countless fathers and mothers come and go, as do numerous sons and wives. The world of saṃsāra is forever in flux, with an endless stream of people passing through. There are innumerable reasons to rejoice and just as many reasons to fear. While the fool suffers daily, the wise remain calm. I cry out, but my pleas fall on deaf ears. Dharma leads to Artha and Kāma, yet it is often neglected. Dharma should never be forsaken for pleasure, fear, greed, or even to save one's life. Happiness and sorrow are both fleeting; only Dharma and the soul are eternal. The body may hold the soul, but it is not everlasting.